

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

Ananya's Notebook

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Ananya's Notebook

The Stolen Flame

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A work of fiction. See “A Note on the Story” at the back of the book for what is invented and what is real.

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Before I Begin



On the last day before winter break, Mrs. Patel handed each of us a notebook. This year, our school won't open again until the day after Sankranti.

She asked us to write on the cover:

PERSONAL JOURNAL

Then she added, "Personal doesn't mean perfect. Personal means honest."

She says *honest* as if it were a door you only have to open.

I think the truth is more like the door to Papa's workshop. It swells when the weather is damp, it scrapes the floor, and it has a blue stripe along one side. You have to push it with your shoulder. Sometimes, even then, it won't open.

Mrs. Patel will collect the notebooks when school starts again. She promised to read only the pages we mark with a star. That is a very adult promise. Adults love promises that assume they'll be able to resist their own curiosity.

So I'm going to put stars on a few pages that don't matter.

I haven't decided about the rest.

My name, Ananya, means "the one who has no equal." Ma chose it. I once asked her if it wasn't a bit of a heavy name for a baby who weighed three kilos. She said that when I was born, I screamed loud enough to carry it.

I live in Jaipur, in an old house built around a courtyard. Papa always calls it *the haveli*, even though one wing is closed off, two windows don't shut anymore, and the roof leaks in three places during the monsoon. The pink walls have faded. The pigeons own the north ledge. The orange cat owns everything else.

Seventeen days from now, it will be Makar Sankranti.

On that day, people climb up to their rooftops before the sun has warmed the stones. Strings cross over the lanes. Voices travel from one roof to the next. The sky doesn't belong to the pigeons or the birds called black kites or the airplanes anymore. It fills up with paper.

In our family, Rohan is the one who flies.

I hold the spool.

Well. That was before this notebook.

PART ONE

The Ones Who Hold the Spool



Chapters 1–4

CHAPTER ONE

1

Other People's Roofs

Saturday, December 28, 2024



The first kite of the season crashed into our courtyard at 8:12 in the morning.

I know because I had just checked the time on Ma's phone. The kite was red, with a yellow star in the middle, and it landed in the bucket where she was soaking laundry.

Ma looked up.

"And so it begins."

She didn't seem annoyed. In Jaipur, two weeks before Makar Sankranti, complaining about kites is like complaining about the sun.

Rohan ran across the courtyard.

His mouth was still full of poha. He plunged his hand into the bucket, pulled out the soaking kite, and examined

its frame like a doctor with a patient who wasn't going to make it.

"Bad bamboo," he announced. "Too thick."

"It fell because it was wet," I said.

"It was doomed before it ever hit the water."

Rohan is fourteen. He has the special confidence of people who know a subject better than you do and fully intend to remind you. In math class, he keeps quiet. When it comes to kites, he could give orders to the wind.

After breakfast, he brought out his charkhi, the wooden spool Papa made for him three years ago. The handles had turned dark from being held so much. On one of them, Rohan had carved his initials with a knife: R.S.

My initials weren't carved anywhere.

We went up to the roof. The cold of the night was still trapped in the stones, but the sun was already warming the wall around the edge. Down in the lanes, shopkeepers were rolling up their metal shutters. A little bell rang near the temple. Farther off, a call to prayer drifted over the houses. The two sounds didn't come from the same place. Here, you learn early to tell directions apart without having to look.

Rohan had bought three paper patangs: a black one, a yellow one, and a white one with a red circle. He chose the black one.

"Here."

He handed me the charkhi.

I knew my place. Two steps behind him, far enough that the string wouldn't tangle around his ankles, close enough to hear his orders.

"Dheel."



I let the spool turn.

“Not that much. Kheench. Now!”

I braked with my palm. The cotton string hummed. Rohan gave two short tugs, then a long one. The black patang hesitated above the wall, dove toward the lane, and pulled up so fast that my stomach did the same thing.

On the roof across from us, the Bansal twins clapped. They’re both very good at launching kites. But whenever their cousin comes over, they always hand him the line and take turns holding his spool.

The patang rose above the antennas.

“Let me try,” I said.

Rohan didn’t answer.

“Just for a minute.”

“You are trying. You’re holding the charkhi.”

“I want the other end.”

He laughed, not in a mean way, which made me even madder.

“The other end is in the sky.”

“You know what I mean.”

A gust tugged on the line. Rohan stepped back and told me to give him slack. His shoulders had changed. When he flew, his whole body was listening. I wished I knew what the string was telling him.

“Later,” he promised.

With Rohan, later usually means *once you’ve forgotten*.

The first time he let me hold the charkhi, I was nine. The spool was almost as wide as my chest. He put my hands on the handles and showed me how to brake without jamming it.

"If you do a good job," he said, "I'll teach you to fly next year."

The next year, he needed someone faster on the spool. Me.

The year after that, he announced that I had gotten too good to replace.

I took that as a compliment. Maybe he did too.

For forty minutes, I let out string, took in string, and kept the spool from jumping off its axle. Two boys set up three roofs away. One of them launched a purple kite. Rohan immediately forgot about my minute.

It wasn't a serious duel. They were all using plain cotton, with no abrasive coating. The lines crossed, separated, and crossed again. Every time, Rohan shouted orders without turning around.

"Dheel!"

"I'm giving you slack!"

"Faster!"

"I only have two hands!"

"Two is the number you're supposed to have!"

I almost laughed. I didn't, on principle.

The purple line finally slid over ours. Rohan yanked hard. The boy across the way yelped. His kite spun in a circle, but neither string snapped. Both pilots raised a hand to call a break.

Rohan finally held out the line to me.

My heart pounded so hard I checked whether the twins could hear it.

I set the charkhi down and reached out my fingers.

"Gently," Rohan said. "Don't squeeze."

The string touched the skin of my first finger.

I felt a light tug, alive, and then a tiny change, as if someone up there had held their breath.

I wanted to correct it.

Rohan took the line back.

“Not now. The wind’s shifting.”

“But you said...”

“Later, Anu.”

This time, his “later” stung all the way down my throat.

I went back behind the spool. I could have argued. I could have put down the charkhi and gone downstairs. Instead, I did what he said when he said *dheel*.

So here is the honest part: nobody tied me to that spool.

I stayed quiet because I was afraid that if I asked for more, they might not even let me come up to the roof anymore.

At noon, Ma called us down for parathas. Rohan brought his patang back without a scratch. On the stairs, he bumped me with his shoulder.

“Good assistant.”

I think he meant it as a thank you.

I also think I hated every letter of that word.



COLOR OF THE DAY: *the black of Rohan’s patang.*

WHAT THIS COLOR SAYS: *from far away, you can’t see who’s holding the line.*

CHAPTER TWO

2

Eight Stitches

Tuesday, December 31, 2024



Rohan came home with eight stitches and four lies. The first lie showed up with him in the auto rickshaw.

“I fell.”

His right arm was held against his chest. A white bandage wrapped his hand all the way to the wrist. Papa paid the driver without arguing and came in behind him.

Ma saw the blood already soaking through a layer of gauze.

“What do you fall on to get cut like that?”

Rohan looked at his shoes.

“Glass.”

Lie number two.

Papa washed his hands at the pump in the courtyard. The water turned blue around his fingers, then gray. He scrubbed longer than usual. Nobody asked him why he had to pick Rohan up from the clinic in Chandpole. Nobody asked how he knew where to find him.

Ma set the medicine on the table.

“What did the doctor say?”

“That a tendon was nicked, but not cut through,” Papa answered. “He has to have the cut checked, go to therapy sessions for his hand, and only move his fingers the way they showed him.”

Rohan tried to bend his first finger. All the color drained out of his face.

Ma gave him a pill and a glass of water. She didn’t yell. She put the same box of medicine away twice.

Papa looked at the charkhi on the shelf.

“You’re not flying this year.”

“The doctor said two weeks for the stitches.”

“I heard the doctor.”

“Sankranti is in two weeks.”

“I heard the calendar too.”

Rohan looked up. For a second, I thought he was going to argue with Papa. Then he pulled his hurt hand against his chest.

Papa went into the workshop. The old door scraped the floor before it shut.

Lie number three, an hour later:

“It barely hurts.”

Rohan was sitting on his bed with his back against the wall. Sweat shone on his upper lip. His empty charkhi was

on the table between us.

I had knocked our secret knock: one knock, a pause, two knocks. He hadn't answered. I went in anyway.

"Show me your fingers."

"No."

"I'm not going to eat them."

"Very funny."

"Thank you."

I sat at the end of the bed. Down in the courtyard, Ma was beating a rug. Every smack made Rohan flinch.

"You didn't fall," I said.

He stared at the bandage.

"There might have been a fall somewhere in the story."

"And maybe some glass?"

His silence changed shape. The locked silence he had kept in front of our parents was gone. What was left was the silence of a door open by a crack.

"I only wanted to look at a spool," he whispered.

"What spool?"

"A spool of synthetic string. The blue string everybody talks about."

I knew the warning posters stuck up near the market: drawings of birds caught in string, the outline of a man on a motorcycle, big red letters. Papa had already told us to stay away from sellers who kept shiny strings under the counter.

"The banned kind?"

"I wasn't going to use it."

Lie number four. He didn't even have the strength to make it a good one.

I didn't say anything.

Rohan swallowed.

“Vikram’s going to have some. Last year, he nearly cut my line in ten seconds. This time, I wanted to know what it felt like in my hand. Just to know.”

“And?”

“The seller took me into the back room. He didn’t want to unroll it in front of the street. I pulled on it. It slipped off the spool when somebody banged on the shutter.”

Rohan closed his eyes.

“I didn’t even understand what happened at first. Then I saw my palm.”

I pictured the blue string stretched between his fingers. You don’t need crushed glass to cut. The thin, strong thread is enough. I looked at his bandage, and my stomach knotted up.

“Did the seller call Papa?”

“No. I called him. I couldn’t stop the bleeding.”

His voice cracked on the last word.

I knew my brother when he was bragging, when he cheated at cards, when he hid the last jalebi in his pocket. I had never seen him ashamed.

“Does Papa know everything?”

“He knows where I was. He doesn’t know I already put down money.”

“With what money?”

“My savings.”

He turned his head toward me.

“Don’t tell him, Anu.”

I didn’t promise right away.

Out in the hallway, Papa moved a metal tub. The clang rolled all the way to us.

“That string hurts birds,” I said.

“I know.”

“And people.”

“I know.”

“You knew before you went.”

He pressed his lips together.

“Vikram’s not going to win fair.”

“That doesn’t make your choice fair.”

He gave a small laugh with no happiness in it.

“You sound like Papa.”

I should have walked out and told them everything. Instead, I looked at the empty charkhi and the folded poster sticking out of his bag. Only two words showed: **ROHAN SHARMA.**

“I won’t say anything,” I whispered.



The gratitude on his face lasted less than a second. After that, he just looked relieved. And I became the keeper of a secret I hadn't chosen.

On the way back to my room, I passed the workshop. Papa was standing behind his worktable, comparing two squares of fabric under a white lamp. His blue hands weren't shaking.

He looked up at me.

I kept walking.

WHAT I DIDN'T SAY TODAY:

1. Rohan wanted to buy the banned string.
2. He had already paid a deposit.
3. I promised to protect him, even though I'm not sure I'm protecting him at all.

CHAPTER THREE

3

The Name on the Poster

Wednesday, January 1, 2025



Rohan's name was still on the wall. The poster had been stuck up next to Gopal Uncle's shop, between an ad for English classes and a notice for a plumber. A strip of tape covered the bottom corner, but you could read it perfectly well:

LANE DUEL
JANUARY 14 AT NOON
ROHAN SHARMA VS. VIKRAM MEHTA

It wasn't an official tournament. There's no great referee of Sankranti who comes down from the sky with a whistle. Our "league" is run by Gopal Uncle, who sells tea, batteries, biscuits, and sometimes opinions nobody asked for. He

writes down the winners in a notebook stained with masala chai. The neighbors accept his decisions because they'd rather argue for three months than write a rulebook.

A group of boys was crowded around the poster. The Joshi brothers were already betting bags of chips on Vikram.

"Rohan's hurt," one of them said. "That counts as a forfeit."

"They haven't crossed his name out yet," the other one answered.

I stepped closer.

"Someone can take his place."

Both brothers turned around.

"Who?"

"Me."

The older one thought I was joking. His laugh made the other one laugh. It wasn't a big, cruel laugh. It was worse: the automatic laugh they would have given me if I'd offered to drive a bus instead of Rohan.

Gopal Uncle came out of his shop carrying a steaming pot.

"What's going on?"

"Ananya wants to take Rohan's place," the older brother announced.

Gopal Uncle looked at me over his glasses.

"Do you know how to fly?"

The right answer would have been no.

"I've held the spool for three years."

"That's not what I asked."

The boys were still snickering. Gopal Uncle was actually waiting for my answer.

“I can learn.”

“In thirteen days?”

“How many days did it take Rohan to fly the first time?”

“More than thirteen.”

“Then leave my name on an empty line. If I’m terrible, Vikram will win fast and you can go back to drinking your tea.”

Gopal Uncle set the pot down on his counter.

“Your family has to agree. And the roof has to have an adult watching.”

“Okay.”

He took off his glasses and wiped them on his vest.

“Your mother used to fly a little when she was younger,” he added.

“Ma?”

“Not the duels. But she knew how to keep a patang in the air. Ask her.”

The Joshi brothers had already lost interest in us. They were arguing about how many spools Vikram had ordered. I stood there in front of Gopal Uncle, surprised by something about my own house that the tea seller knew better than I did.

“Why didn’t anybody ever tell me?”

“Maybe because you never asked,” he said.

That sentence followed me all the way home. It was fair and unfair at the same time. How are you supposed to ask about a door nobody ever told you existed? And how can

you blame other people for not opening it if you never went looking for the handle?

I had said okay too fast. My family hadn't agreed to anything, because they didn't know about anything.

When I got home, Rohan was in the courtyard doing the exercises the doctor had given him: lift the first finger, relax, repeat. His face tightened with every movement.

"Your name is still on the poster," I told him.

"I know."

"Gopal Uncle will accept a substitute."

He stopped moving.

"Who?"

"Me."

Rohan looked at me exactly the way the Joshi brothers had. Then he didn't laugh.

"You don't know how to launch."

"You can teach me."

"In thirteen days?"

"Everybody keeps saying the same thing today. Did you all start a group chat?"

He looked down at his hand.

"Papa will never say yes."

"Maybe Ma will."

"Ma will tell him."

"Then I'll fly without asking."

Rohan's head came up so fast that I was sorry I'd said it.

"No."

"You went looking for a banned string without asking."

"Look what it cost me."

"Exactly. Teach me with a normal string."

He got up and left the courtyard. A minute later, his bedroom door slammed.

At dinner, I tried a different road.

"If Rohan can't compete, somebody could take his place."

Papa kept eating without looking up. Ma put lentils in my bowl.

"Gopal Uncle said a substitute would be allowed," I added.

"The Joshi boys have cousins," Ma said.

"I'm not talking about their cousins."

Rohan shot me a warning look.

"I could do it."

This time, nobody laughed.

Ma set down the ladle.

"Have you ever flown by yourself?"

"Not yet."

Papa kept eating.

"I know the charkhi, the string, the signals. I'm up on the roof every year."

"You help your brother," Papa said.

It was the first thing he had said since dinner started.

"Yes. And now I want to fly."

"This year, nobody from this house is entering the duel."

"Why?"

He looked at Rohan's hand. The answer was sitting at the table with us.

"Because a game that leads you into a forbidden back room isn't a game anymore."

Ma turned toward Rohan. He went very still.

So Papa knew about the string. Maybe not about the money, but enough.

"I wouldn't use anything dangerous," I said.

"No."

One word. Papa can build a wall with a single word.

I looked at Ma. She didn't come to my rescue.

"You never asked before today," she said softly.

"Because nobody ever offered."

"Asking sooner might have helped."

"So it's my fault that nobody sees me?"

I stood up. My knee hit the table, and the bowls rattled.

"Sit down," Papa said.

I walked out.

That was my choice on New Year's Day: I didn't obey.

It wasn't brave yet, just fast and hot and silent, like stepping on a burning stone and running before you can think.

That night, I pinned the copy of the duel poster I had drawn on my bedroom wall. Under Rohan's name, I wrote mine in pencil.

The lead broke halfway through the second a.

I sharpened the pencil and started again.

CHAPTER FOUR

4

The Color That Failed

Thursday, January 2, 2025



Papa counts everything.

The meters of cotton that come into the workshop. The mother-of-pearl buttons in their little bags. The spoonfuls of powder. The minutes a dye bath has to stay at a certain temperature. Even the scraps he sets aside get written down in a black notebook.

Once, when I was ten, he asked me to sort some blue ribbons from lightest to darkest. I made five piles in three minutes. He mixed them up and put them by the door. In the sunlight, two ribbons I had thought were identical didn't look anything alike.

"Color never lives alone," he told me. "It changes with the light, the fabric, and whatever you put next to it."

I asked if that meant no color was ever true.

“They’re all true in their own conditions.”

After that, Rohan came in with a bill. Papa showed him how to write down the batch numbers. I got sent out to play in the courtyard.

I still remembered what he said about colors. I also remembered the bill.

I knew the workshop wasn’t a place for me.

I went in anyway.

Papa had gone to deliver samples to a shop in Johari Bazaar. Ma was buying vegetables. Rohan was asleep because of his medicine. The workshop door had swollen in its frame. I pushed it with my shoulder until it gave.

The smell wrapped around me: wet fabric, iron, soap, sawdust, and something bitter that stays in the back of your nose. Lengths of cotton were drying on a rod. One was dark red. Another had little blue flowers printed by hand in a workshop in Sanganer, which was sent to Papa to fix the color.

Papa is not “a master dyer from a family that goes back centuries,” the way I once told Meena to impress her. Our family didn’t invent the colors of Jaipur. He works with printers, shops, and tailors. He adjusts dye baths, rescues uneven batches, compares shades, and finishes fabric that other hands have spun, woven, or printed. He says a good color carries a lot of invisible names.

But on the bills, when something goes wrong, the only name there is his.

At the back of the room, six squares were lined up on the table. Papa had numbered them in pencil.

KESARIYA 38

KESARIYA 39

KESARIYA 40

The next three were crossed out.

The last one, number 43, was a strange color. Not the bright orange of the plastic flags sold at intersections. Not the yellow of the turmeric on Ma's cutting board. It was a deep saffron, streaked with red in the places where the cloth had soaked up more dye.

Papa had explained to me that *kesariya* was the name of a color. It didn't mean he poured the saffron threads Ma saves for holidays into his vats. This shade came from several baths and experiments with dyes whose recipes he recorded but never left open for anyone to read.

Square 43 hadn't taken the color evenly.

It was beautiful.

I picked it up. The cotton was fine, stronger than it looked. In the light from the window, the red patches looked like little embers.

Under the samples, Papa's black notebook had been left open.

I read it without meaning to:

ARORA ORDER: DUPATTAS. NEW PRESENTATION JANU-
ARY 10. REDO 43. DO NOT CUT.

I put the fabric down.

Then I picked it up again.

In my head, a very practical voice got to work. *The square is small. Papa has five other samples. He crossed it out. He can't*

sell an uneven color. A kite only needs a mark, not a whole dupatta. You'll put it back after the duel.

The last sentence was so stupid I should have realized all the others were stupid too. How do you put fabric back after you've cut it?

Footsteps crossed the courtyard.

I slid the square under my sweater.

The door opened.

Papa was holding a stack of receipts. His fingers had the blue stains that never completely wash off, even when he scrubs with soap and lemon.

"What are you doing in here?"

The fabric seemed to give off its own heat against my stomach.

"I was looking for glue."

"For what?"

"Mrs. Patel's notebook."

He set down the receipts.

"The paper glue is in the kitchen drawer."

"Oh."

I stayed one second too long. His eyes moved down to my hands, then to the table.

"Ananya."

I didn't move.

"Yes?"

"Close the door tight on your way out. Dust sticks to wet fabric."

I nodded.



In the hallway, I didn't run. Running would have looked like stealing. I walked to my room, shut the door, and pulled the square out from under my sweater.

At that exact moment, the temple bell rang. A scooter honked in the lane. Somebody shouted the price of oranges. The world didn't notice a thing.

I had thought stealing would make some kind of special noise.

It turns out it fits in one hand, and the rest of the house keeps breathing.

● **COLOR OF THE DAY:** *Kesariya 43.*

WHAT I REFUSE TO WRITE ABOUT IT: *It wasn't a reject.*

PART TWO

Agni



Chapters 5–9

CHAPTER FIVE

5

Three Knocks

Friday, January 3, 2025



One knock. A pause. Two knocks.
This time, Rohan answered.

“Come in.”

He was at his desk. His bandaged hand was resting on a folded towel. With his left hand, he was trying to draw the frame of a patang on a sheet of graph paper. All the lines leaned the same way.

“You draw like a sick chicken,” I said.

“Oh good. I was hoping for some useful criticism.”

I shut the door behind me.

“I have something.”

The kesariya square was tucked into the waistband of my pants. I pulled it out and put it on his bed.

Rohan stopped smiling.

He touched the edge of the fabric with his left hand, then looked at the number written in one corner.

“Number 43.”

“You know it?”

“Papa’s been working on it for a week. He said the client wanted a color that stays bright in the shade.”

The square on his bed suddenly looked a lot more important.

“He crossed it out.”

“He crosses out samples before he redoes them.”

“Are you sure?”

Rohan pointed at the number.

“Why else would he keep the number?”

I wanted to grab the fabric and put it right back in the workshop. I even reached for it.

Then I thought about my name in pencil, under his.

“He might not notice one square.”

“Papa notices when three buttons are missing from a bag of a hundred.”

“Are you going to help me or give me a lecture?”

“I can do both.”

I sat down across from him.

“You wanted to beat Vikram with a banned string.”

“And now I have eight stitches in my hand.”

“So help me beat him another way.”

Rohan looked at the fabric, at his bandage, then at the crooked drawing on his desk.

“You want to use it for the sail?”

“Yes.”

"It's thin cotton, but it's still going to be heavier than paper. We'll need stiffer sticks."

"We can try."

"We?"

"You build it. I fly it."

He leaned back in his chair.

"And if I say no?"

I picked up the square and pretended to stand up.

"I'll build it without you."

He burst out laughing.

"You'd glue the bamboo on the wrong side."

"I'll watch a video."

His laugh stopped. As far as Rohan is concerned, internet videos are useful for noodle recipes and dangerous for anything to do with kites.

"Sit down."

I waited.

"If we do this," he went on, "you follow my plan. I choose the frame, the line, and the moves. On the roof, you listen to my signals. No making things up."

"I'll be the pilot."

"Yes."

"My name will be on the poster."

He hesitated.

"Your name and mine."

"Why yours?"

"Because it's my duel."

We sat there without talking. I see it now: Rohan wasn't offering me his place. He was looking for a way to keep it, using my body.

But right then, all I could see was a door finally opening a crack.

“Deal,” I said.

He held out his left hand. I shook it.

“First,” he said, “we need to find out if your fingers understand anything.”

He took a spool of ordinary cotton and tied the end to the handle of the wardrobe. Then he handed me the other end.

“Pull.”

I pulled.

“Not like you’re trying to move the wardrobe.”

“You said pull.”

“You have to feel it first.”

“Feel what?”

“Exactly.”

He tucked a pillow under his good arm and pushed it against the string. The tension changed.

“Here comes the wind,” he said. “What do you do?”

I pulled harder.

The pillow fell.

“You just killed the wind.”

“That was your pillow.”

“Same problem.”

For an hour, we worked between the bed and the wardrobe. He pushed, let go, and changed the angle. I had to respond without watching what he was doing.

When I got it wrong, he said *again*.

When I got it right, he didn’t say anything.

I finally figured out that his silence could also mean good.

Before dinner, we spread the kesariya square on the floor. Inside its uneven shape, a red point rose toward the middle.

“It looks like a flame,” I said.

Rohan traced the mark with his finger.

“Agni.”

“Fire?”

“Yes.”

I wrote the name on the back of our drawing.

I left out the line across the A. Rohan added it with his left hand.

Then we drew three versions of Agni. In the first, the flame covered the whole sail. In the second, Rohan wanted to add a long tail to keep the fabric steady. In the third, I drew two flames meeting in the middle.

“Too fancy,” he kept saying.

“Too boring,” I kept answering.

For half an hour, we argued about lines that didn’t exist yet. It was almost like before he got hurt, when we could waste time without every minute pulling us closer to a duel.

Rohan took a little red patang out of his drawer. One side was crumpled.

“My first kite,” he said.

“You kept it?”

“Papa built the frame. I glued on the paper. It crashed nine times.”

“And the tenth time?”

“It flew all the way to the Bansals’ roof. Then it fell into their water tank.”

I laughed.

He put the patang back in the drawer carefully.

“People always tell the story of their first flight like it was amazing. Most of the time, it’s just wet paper.”

KNOT LEARNED: *The starting knot.*

Cross it, loop it back, pull it tight.

If you pull it tight before you check it, you have to undo the whole thing.

CHAPTER SIX

6

Dheel, Kheench

Saturday, January 4, 2025



At nine o'clock, my fingers didn't know anything.
By noon, they knew that they hurt.

In between, Rohan taught me two words I already knew without really knowing them.

Dheel: give slack.

Kheench: pull in.

They're simple words when you say them in a bedroom.
Out in the wind, they turn into decisions.

We started in the courtyard. Rohan had hung an old patang from the clothesline. When he pulled one corner with his left hand, I had to let the cotton run out. When he let go, I had to take the line back in.

The orange cat decided the whole exercise had been set up for him. He pounced on the patang and crossed the

courtyard with half a sheet of yellow paper stuck to his paw.

Rohan laughed so hard that he banged his hurt hand against the back of his chair.

After that, he didn't laugh for several minutes.

"Did you take your medicine?"

"Yes."

"A real yes or a fake yes?"

"Worry about your own fingers."

They were turning red. The cotton string wasn't sharp like the one that had cut Rohan, but it kept rubbing in the same place.

"Wrap it around your finger," he suggested.

I started to.

Then I looked at his bandage.

"No."

"What do you mean, no?"

"If a gust pulls, the string tightens around your finger."

He opened his mouth, then shut it again.

We found another way. In the first aid box, I found some protective tape. I washed my hands, dried them well, and covered the red spots. Rohan wrote on his sheet: **NEVER WRAP THE STRING AROUND YOUR FINGERS.**

"You're writing that like it was your idea," I pointed out.

"I'm just writing down the final truth."

At two o'clock, he decided we could go up to the small inner terrace. It has a wall around it that comes up almost to my shoulders, and it doesn't look directly out over the street. Papa dries some of his fabric there. That day, the lines were empty.

Rohan checked the door, the paving stones, and the distance to the edge.

“We don’t run. We never back up without looking. If the patang falls, we let it fall.”

“You sound like Papa.”

“That’s been happening since Tuesday.”

We were using the white patang with the red circle, not Agni. Rohan didn’t want to risk our fabric until I knew how to hold a line.

He launched it with his left hand. The first try ended against the wall.

The second one landed on his head.

“Very graceful,” I said.

“The wind’s bad.”

“Of course it is.”

On the third try, a wind gust caught the paper. I felt the line go tight and pulled with all my strength.

The patang dove.

“Dheel!” Rohan shouted.

I gave it string. Too much. The spool spun so fast it jumped off its stand. Rohan stopped it with his foot while I grabbed the line.

The patang hit the wall, bounced, and caught a little air again.

“Kheench, now. Not with your shoulders. With your wrists.”

I pulled twice.

The red circle rose a meter.

My whole body wanted to keep pulling. It seemed obvious: if I wanted the patang to go up, I had to force it up.

“Wait,” Rohan said.

I waited.

The string was humming between my taped fingers. A little shiver ran all the way down to my palm.

“Now. Dheel.”

I opened my hand just enough.

The patang tilted, slid along the breeze, and straightened out higher than before.

I let out a shriek.

“Don’t celebrate every meter,” Rohan said.

He was smiling.

For six minutes, the patang stayed up above the terrace. Six minutes when my fingers picked up something my eyes couldn’t see. The gusts had different weights. Some of them yanked all at once. Others settled in slowly. When I stopped fighting, I could feel them better.



We brought the patang down during a lull. Rohan wanted to adjust the bridle. He pinched the string between his left thumb and finger, but the knot kept slipping. His right hand came up, out of habit. The pain stopped it before he touched the cotton.

"Give it to me," I said.

"I can do it."

The knot came undone.

"I see that."

He glared at me, then put the bridle in my palm.

He had to explain every step: under the loop, around, then back without pulling tight. The first time, I trapped a twist in it. The second time, the knot slipped. On the third try, it held.

"Not too tight," Rohan said. "The paper has to be able to move a little."

I stopped myself from saying that people do too.

When he took the bridle back, his face had the same look it had the day he handed me the line: afraid of losing his place, and relieved that he didn't have to do everything alone.

After we launched it again, I wanted to go higher.

I pulled in too much of the line. The patang spun, nose-dived, and disappeared behind the wall.

A crumpling sound floated up from the courtyard.

The cat shot under the charpai.

"Six minutes," Rohan said.

"Six minutes and one death."

"It was old anyway."

We went back down. The patang had lost a corner, but it could be fixed.

Rohan wrote my results on his sheet.

ANANYA'S SCORE

- *Time in the air: 6 minutes*
- *Mistakes: 11*
- *Crashes: 1*
- *Listening to instructions: needs work*

I took his pencil and added:

- *ROHAN'S FAILED LAUNCHES: 2*

He crossed out my line.

I wrote it again.

That evening, I took the tape off my fingers. Two spots were sore, but the skin wasn't broken. I washed my hands and put on clean bandages.

I would like to write that the pain proved how brave I was. It only proved that the string was rubbing too hard and that I needed to fix my grip.

The part I wanted to keep wasn't the burn.

It was the second when I gave it slack and the patang went up.

CHAPTER SEVEN

7

What Meena Sees

Sunday, January 5, 2025



Meena sees the things people tuck away behind them. She sees the old price under a new sticker. She sees when a teacher forgets to call on the back row. She sees the piece of cilantro stuck in your teeth and tells you before you smile at the whole class.

Today, she saw Agni.

She had come over to work on our holiday homework. Mrs. Patel had asked us to write down five sounds from our neighborhood and what each one was trying to say. Meena had already written eight sounds, including “Gopal Uncle’s shutter, which squeaks like it’s protesting against the shop opening.”

I had two.

We were in my room when Rohan knocked our special knock.

One knock. A pause. Two knocks.

Without waiting, he stuck his head in.

"The wind is turning northeast. If we want to test it before..."

He saw Meena.

Meena saw the bundle of bamboo sticks under his arm, the spool in his left hand, and the piece of kesariya sticking out of my notebook box.

Nobody said anything.

The orange cat walked in, sensed the silence, and walked right back out.

"Test what?" Meena asked.

"Homework," I said.

"Your homework has bamboo?"

"It's very thorough homework."

She got up and opened the box before I could stop her. The square of fabric unrolled across my notebooks.

"It's beautiful," she said.

Then she looked at my face.

"And it isn't yours."

It wasn't a question.

Rohan backed toward the hallway.

"Don't move," Meena ordered him.

Fourteen years old, king of three and a half roofs, my brother obeyed.

I told her everything, except for the line in Papa's notebook. I said the fabric was a failed sample headed for the scrap pile. I said I would put it back. I didn't explain how.

Meena and I became friends when we were eight, because of an eraser. I had accused a boy of taking mine. Meena found the eraser stuck to the bottom of my own shoe. She didn't laugh at me in front of everybody. She just said, "You should look before you accuse people."

At the next break, she sat down with me.

Ever since then, she's been the one who looks. For both of us, a lot of the time. She catches mistakes before they turn into disasters, and she keeps quiet about things that aren't putting anyone in danger.

That's why my lie mattered: I wasn't only hiding a project, I was treating her discretion as something she owed me.

Meena listened without interrupting.

"So," she summed up, "Rohan went looking for a banned string, got hurt, you kept his secret, then you took fabric from the workshop without asking, and now the two of you are getting ready for a duel your parents said no to."

"When you say it like that, it sounds bad."

"I said it in the order it happened."

Rohan leaned against the door.

"Are you going to turn us in?"

"I'm not your babysitter."

"That's not an answer."

"I'm not going to run and tell your parents. But I won't lie if they ask me something."

I crossed my arms.

"Very helpful friend."

Meena flinched. Just a little, but I saw it.

“A helpful friend is one who lets you do whatever you want?”

I was sorry I'd said it. Not fast enough to take it back.

She touched the kesariya with the tip of her finger.

“Are you sure your father was going to throw it out?”

“It was crossed out.”

“That's not what I asked.”

Everybody was asking the right questions lately.

“Almost sure.”

The *almost* came out all by itself.

Meena breathed out through her nose.

“At least show me what you're doing.”

On the inner terrace, Rohan set up the old patang we had fixed. Meena didn't look at the sky first. She checked the paving stones, the wall, and the string.

“What's it made of?”

“Plain cotton,” Rohan said.

“No powder on it?”

“Nothing.”

“And do you have someone to go after it if it falls?”

“We don't go after it.”

Meena took out her phone. She had downloaded an app that showed the wind direction and speed.

“Northeast, eleven kilometers an hour,” she said.

Rohan frowned.

“I knew that without a phone.”

“Congratulations. The phone also gives you a number.”

During the test, Meena wrote down every time the wind dropped and every mistake. When I pulled too early, she

wrote it down. When Rohan shouted two opposite instructions three seconds apart, she wrote that down too.

“Whose side are you on?” he protested.

“The facts’.”

After twelve minutes, I brought the patang down without crashing it.

Meena wrote **12 MINUTES** at the top of the page. I wanted to smile at her. Her face was still closed.

On the way down, she stopped by the crack in the courtyard wall. A dried jasmine flower had been stuck there since her last visit. She pulled it out and crushed it into dust between her fingers.

“I’ll help you with safety and measurements,” she said. “Not with hiding the theft.”

“Okay.”

“And you have to give the fabric back before it gets cut.”

I looked at Rohan.

He looked at the red flame in the middle of the square.

“Okay,” I said again.

That word was my lie of the day.

WHAT I DIDN'T TELL MEENA:

- *Papa had written “do not cut.”*
- *The fabric was supposed to be shown to a client.*
- *If she made me choose right now, I would choose Agni.*

CHAPTER EIGHT

8

Agni's First Flight

Monday, January 6, 2025



Agni flew for two seconds.
Then it hit a pot of cilantro.

The pot broke. The cilantro survived. Agni barely did.

We had spent the whole morning building it in Rohan's room. Two bamboo sticks made its spine and its bow. We stretched the kesariya square over them, reinforced the edges with paper, and tied on the bridle using Rohan's measurements.

He kept saying the fabric was too heavy.

I kept saying we hadn't tried it yet.

Meena kept saying that saying something again doesn't change how much it weighs.

At noon, up on the terrace, Rohan launched Agni with his left hand. I took the line. A gust filled the fabric. The red

flame rose above the wall.

One second.

Two seconds.

Then the crosspiece bent. Agni spun and threw itself toward the courtyard as if it had found the shortest way to the ground.

The crash of the pot brought Ma out of the kitchen.

We dropped flat behind the terrace wall.

"What fell?" she shouted.

"A pot!" I shouted back.

"I can see it's a pot! Why?"

Rohan whispered, "The wind."

"The wind!" I shouted.

Ma muttered something about children and holidays that go on too long. A door slammed downstairs.

I went and got Agni. The fabric wasn't torn, but one corner had come unglued.

"The wind shifted," I said.

"No," Meena said.

"You were behind the wall."

"I saw the stick bend."

Rohan picked up the frame.

"It's too heavy. If I make it stronger, it'll just get heavier."

"You picked the bamboo."

"For the fabric you picked."

"So it's my fault?"

"It's a kite, Anu. It doesn't need someone to blame. It needs to be lighter."

I held Agni tight against me. The kesariya had lost some of its shine where the glue had dried.

“We start over,” Meena said.

“With what?”

“With someone who actually knows how to make them.”

That afternoon, she dragged me all the way to the Handipura market. We had told Ma we were buying paper for our homework. That wasn't completely false, which is a liar's favorite kind of food.

As we got closer, the lanes filled up with patangs. They hung in front of the shops by the dozen: little diamonds of paper in pink, lime green, purple, black, gold. Charkhis were stacked as high as my shoulders. Kids were comparing prices. Fathers were testing spools. Two women were arguing about how much a stick should curve, with more authority than Rohan.

Meena elbowed me.

“See?”

“See what?”

“The women. They didn't disappear from the market.”

“I never said every girl in Jaipur was banned from the sky.”

“No. But sometimes you talk about your roof like it's the whole city.”

I didn't answer.

We stopped in front of a narrow shop. A woman with silver hair was fixing a blue patang. The sign said **FARIDA PATANG HOUSE**.

“What are you looking for?” she asked, without looking up.

“Strong paper,” I said.

“For decorating or for flying?”

“Flying.”

She finally looked at the bundle in my arms. I had wrapped Agni in an old sheet.

“Show me.”

I hesitated, then unwrapped what we had built.

Farida Auntie put down the blue patang and picked Agni up by the bridle.

“Pretty color. Bad kite.”

“It only got two seconds of wind.”

“It got two seconds more than it deserved.”

Meena hid a smile.

Farida Auntie bent the bamboo slightly.

“A fighter has to be light and able to flex. Paper listens faster than cloth. If you love this color, keep a small piece of it. Don’t force the whole square to become the sky.”



She picked out an unfinished patang and showed us the back. A very thin stick made the spine. The crosspiece wasn't perfectly even. It had been adjusted so the sail would answer the wind, instead of just looking straight on a table.

"People look at the design," Farida Auntie said. "Flying usually depends on what they can't see."

In the back room, a young man was cutting paper around an old, worn pattern. An old woman was rolling little dots of glue. Farida Auntie explained that some kites came from other cities and others were put together in the lanes around the market. Every pair of hands did one part. Even a patang that sold for a few rupees might have passed through several houses.

"So who made it?" I asked.

"Everyone who touched it the right way," she answered. "And the person who breaks it while bragging will still say, my patang."

Meena looked at me. I asked her not to start.

Farida Auntie checked my fingers too. She approved of the tape and refused to sell me anything else until I promised not to practice alone.

"A roof doesn't forgive you just because you have a good story," she said.

She showed us how to choose two thin sticks, one of them carefully curved. We bought ivory paper, a red sheet, and a small spool of plain cotton.

Near the counter, a poster showed a bird caught in a blue thread.

A man asked in a low voice if the shop sold "stronger strings."

Farida Aunty pointed at the poster.

"Only ordinary cotton here."

The man kept pushing. She handed back his money without another word.

On the walk home, Meena carried the paper. I carried Agni.

"She was right," I finally said.

"I'm going to write down the date."

We took the first Agni apart without Rohan. I peeled off the fabric slowly with a little warm water. Some threads stayed stuck to the paper on the edges. Every thread I pulled away reminded me that this square wasn't mine.

I cut out a flame the size of my palm around the red part, keeping the numbered corner at its base. I rolled up the rest and hid it in my box.

When Rohan saw the new ivory paper sail, he pinched his mouth shut.

"You went to Handipura without me."

"You can't go out for long yet," I said.

"I could have told you all of that."

"You did tell her," Meena said. "Ananya didn't listen."

"Thanks, Meena."

"Facts."

We glued the kesariya flame into the middle of the sail. It wasn't carrying all the wind anymore. It marked Agni without weighing it down.

This version hasn't flown yet.

But when I held it up to the window, the paper shivered at the smallest breath of air.

I hated admitting it: the first Agni was a bad patang, even if it was beautiful.

The cilantro pot probably wishes I had figured that out sooner.

CHAPTER NINE

9

Ma's Feet

Tuesday, January 7, 2025



Ma caught us because of my heels. Rohan said I only flew with my hands. Meena said my whole body moved, but always one second too late. I said they both had a lot of opinions for people who weren't holding the line.

We were testing the new Agni on the inner terrace. Ma was supposed to be visiting Aunt Kavita.

She came back for her shawl.

Agni was floating six meters above the wall. I was watching the sky, not the stairs. When the wind changed, I rocked back on my heels with my legs stiff.

"Bend your knees," Ma said.

I let out too much string.

Rohan stopped the charkhi with his foot.

Meena turned off her phone as if the wind app were the main evidence of our crime.

Ma stood in the doorway to the terrace with her shawl over her arm.

“Bring it down,” she said.

“I can explain.”

“Bring the kite down first.”

I took the line back. My hands were shaking. Agni tilted.

“Not just your arms,” Ma said. “Your weight is too far back.”

“How do you know?”

“Bring it down.”

I bent my legs. When the pull came back, I stepped forward with one foot instead of yanking with my shoulders. Agni stopped wobbling. I guided it down toward the terrace while Rohan slowly wound the line back in.

The kite landed in my hands.

Ma waited until the spool was on the ground.

“Now explain.”

All three of us talked at the same time.

Rohan said it was his idea.

I said that wasn’t true.

Meena said the string was plain cotton.

Ma held up her hand.

“Ananya. Just you.”

I told her about the duel, the poster, and the practice. I left out the string Rohan had gone looking for, because Papa already knew about that, and I left out the theft, because Ma didn’t know yet. By the end, there was so little truth left in

my story that it felt like I had served her an almost empty bowl.

She picked up Agni. Her eyes stopped on the kesariya flame.

“This fabric came from the workshop.”

“Papa wasn’t using it anymore.”

“He gave it to you?”

One syllable could have stopped everything.

“Yes.”

The lie came out clean.

Rohan looked down. Meena looked straight at me.

Ma ran her finger along the edge of the paper.

“Your father told you no to the duel, and gave you fabric for the kite?”

“Not for the duel. For a project.”

She knew there was a hole somewhere. She just didn’t know where yet.

“I’ll talk to him.”

“Ma...”

“Later. First, the rules.”

She leaned Agni against the wall and turned to me.

“Never alone on a roof. Never near the edge. Closed shoes. Water. You don’t run after a falling kite. You don’t touch any string you find in the street. And if your skin breaks, you stop.”

“So you’re saying yes?”

“I’m saying yes to you learning in front of me. I didn’t say anything about the duel.”

She left her sandals by the door and put on the closed shoes Papa keeps for the workshop. Then she set her feet

side by side on the stones.

“Take the line again.”

“Do you know how to fly?”

“Not like your brother. But I know how to spot someone who’s about to fall.”

She moved her right foot, bent her knees, and turned her waist a little. The movement was precise and silent.

“I studied kathak for six years,” she said. “Before you two were born, and for a little while after Rohan.”

“Did you want to be a dancer?”

“Some days. Other days, I only wanted to get through one routine without my ankle swelling up.”

She smiled.

“My life before you isn’t a sad story you can use to win an argument. I stopped for a lot of reasons. Some of them are mine. Now, watch my feet.”

She added that she had loved dancing, and then loved teaching it for a few years to kids in the neighborhood. She had also hated the exams, the swollen ankles, and a teacher who banged his cane on the floor every time she lost the beat.

“Dreams don’t always get stolen by one person,” she said. “Sometimes they change. Sometimes you let them change. Sometimes you miss part of it and not the rest.”

“What do you miss?”

“I miss practicing. I don’t regret having Rohan and you, if that’s the dramatic answer you were waiting for.”

“I wasn’t waiting for anything dramatic.”

“You keep a diary. You’re always waiting for something dramatic.”

She was right.

Then her face got serious again.

"And don't take my story as permission to lie. If I help you find your balance, you'll still have to answer for how you got up on this roof."

She showed me how to shift my weight without crossing my legs, how to keep my center steady, and how to turn my upper body without backing up blind.

"Your brother listens to the string with his wrists," she said. "You'll have to listen with the floor too."

For twenty minutes, I didn't fly Agni at all. I practiced steps on the stones while Rohan called out the direction of each imaginary gust. Meena called out *gust on the right, short pull, let go.*

Ma fixed my feet.



“Again.”

The way she said it sounded like Rohan, but she left more air around the word.

At the end, Agni went back up into the sky. When a gust pulled me backward, I bent my knees and stepped forward with my right foot.

The line stayed steady.

“Better,” Ma said.

Just one word.

With her, it could mean a lot too.

On the way down, she took Agni with her.

“I’m keeping this until you’ve talked to your father.”

Meena waited for me in the courtyard.

“You lied to her,” she said.

“I’m going to give back the rest of the fabric.”

“When?”

“After the festival.”

“That will be after you’ve cut it, glued it, and flown it.”

I looked at the crack in the wall. It was empty.

“You don’t understand.”

“I understand that you want Agni to matter more than how you made it.”

She put her phone back in her pocket.

“I’ll come back tomorrow for Mrs. Patel’s homework. Not for practice.”

She left through the little side door.

Above us, the sky was perfectly clear.

And yet I had never seen so many things left hanging.

PART THREE

The Line That Cuts



Chapters 10–14

CHAPTER TEN

10

The Bird and the Blue Line

Wednesday, January 8, 2025



The bird fell at 10:27.

I didn't check the time. Meena wrote it down.

She had come back to finish our homework on neighborhood sounds, like she'd promised. Not for practice. She had put her notebook on the charpai and wouldn't even look toward the stairs to the roof.

Ma was keeping Agni in the cupboard in her bedroom.

"Did you talk to Papa?" she had asked me at breakfast.

"He left early."

"That's not an answer."

"I'll talk to him tonight."

She had pressed her lips together. She was giving me the day.

Meena and I were listening to the street when a shadow swept across the courtyard. At first, I thought a sheet had blown off somebody's roof. Then something crashed into the jasmine, there was a huge beating of wings, and Meena screamed.

A black kite was lying by the wall. Not the paper kind. The bird.

Its wings were bigger than I would ever have imagined. One was beating against the stones. The other was caught in a loop of blue filament, almost invisible except when it caught the light. The line ran up through the jasmine, over the ledge, and disappeared toward the lane.

The orange cat shot out from under the charpai.

I ran toward the bird.

"Don't touch it!" Meena yelled.

I stopped two steps away.

Its beak was hooked. Its black eyes followed every move I made. There was blood on the feathers under its wing.

Ma came out of the kitchen holding a wooden spoon.

"Both of you, back up."

"We have to get the string off," I said.

"Not with your hands."

She shut the cat in the kitchen, then herded us under the archway. The bird kept thrashing. Every movement pulled the blue loop tighter.

Meena took out her phone.

"There was a number on the poster at Farida Aunty's shop."

She had taken a picture of it. Of course she had. Meena takes pictures of the things other people forget to look at.

She called the bird rescue line. A woman asked for our address, what kind of bird it was if we knew, where it had landed, and whether the string was touching any power lines.

“No,” Meena said. “It’s caught on a bush and on the ledge. We’re not touching it.”

Ma nodded.

Rohan came down when he heard the crash. When he saw the line, his face went pale.

“Is it the same blue?” I asked.

“I don’t know.”

He knew.

The bird tried to stand up. The loop cut deeper into its feathers. I looked away.

“Why doesn’t somebody just cut the string up there?”

“Because we can’t see where it goes,” Ma said. “And if it’s pulled tight, it can whip back and hit someone. We wait.”

Waiting lasted eleven minutes.

I counted every breath the bird took. Rohan stared at the filament without a word. Meena kept answering texts from the rescue worker. Ma had set a big cardboard box by the door with a cloth in the bottom, but she didn’t go near the bird.

Two volunteers arrived: a woman with thick gloves, and a man carrying a light blanket, safety glasses, and a long pole. They asked us to stay inside.

The woman laid the blanket over the bird to keep it still. The man let the line go slack from the ledge before he cut it with a tool. They worked slowly. Nobody did anything dramatic. Nobody grabbed the bird with bare hands.



When they lifted it, I saw a gash under its wing.

“Is it going to die?” I asked.

The volunteer didn’t answer too fast.

“It’s breathing well. The wing is hurt, and we need to check the tendons. We’re taking it to the center. You did the right thing, calling instead of trying to pull the string off.”

She showed us the blue filament. They had wound it around a piece of cardboard.

“This kind of line stays dangerous even after the festival. If you find any, don’t pull on it, and don’t pick it up with bare hands. Tell an adult.”

Rohan had lowered his head.

“Is it synthetic string?” Meena asked.

“Yes. Very thin and very strong. It can hurt a bird, someone riding a bike, or the person holding it.”

The box closed over the bird. The rustling went on for a few seconds, then everything went quiet.

The volunteer asked for a phone number so she could send us news. Meena gave hers before Ma could finish her sentence.

Before they left, the volunteers pulled as much of the line out of the jasmine as they could. Part of it still ran over the wall. They tied a bright ribbon at the dangerous spot and left their number so Papa could call them back once they could get onto the neighbors' roof.

After they left, the courtyard felt smaller.

An hour later, a text came in: the bird had a deep cut but no broken bones. They were keeping it for observation.

Rohan read the message twice.

"So it'll fly again?"

"They don't know yet," Meena said.

"But it's alive."

"Yes."

He sat down by the pump and looked at the feather left on the ground. He was looking for an ending that would let him breathe: the bird would live, so what he had planned to do would count for less. I wanted that ending too.

A gray feather was still lying by the pump. Meena picked it up with a scrap of paper and slipped it into one of our homework envelopes.

"It's not a souvenir," she said. "It's for Mrs. Patel. Sound number nine: a wing against the stones."

Rohan sat down on the charpai.

"I wouldn't have used the spool for long."

Ma turned to him.

“What spool?”

He looked at me.

The secret I had agreed to keep was finally standing right in front of us. It was wearing a white bandage, and it had nowhere left to hide.

“The one I wanted to buy,” he said. “The string that cut me.”

He told Ma everything. The back room of the shop, the deposit, the blood, Papa coming to get him. His voice got quieter with every sentence.

Ma didn’t interrupt. When he was done, she asked:

“And you, Ananya. Did you know?”

“Since the day he got hurt.”

“And you decided not to say anything.”

It wasn’t a question.

“He asked me not to.”

“You can love your brother and still refuse to carry his lie.”

Rohan started to say something. She raised her hand.

“And you. You don’t turn your sister into a safe when what you’re locking away can hurt someone.”

The word *safe* stung, because it was true. Rohan had handed me his secret, then left me to carry the weight of it.

Ma had us pick up the scraps of cotton string and paper lying around on the roof, wearing gardening gloves, with her watching. Meena started a new page in her notebook:

LOG OF STRINGS FOUND

Date, color, location, what it’s probably made of, which adult we told.

“Are you really going to write down every string?” I asked.

“The ones we can pick up safely.”

“That won’t bring the bird back.”

“No. But maybe it’ll keep another one from falling into our courtyard.”

That evening, I added a rule on the back of Rohan’s sheet:

AGNI WILL ONLY FLY WITH PLAIN COTTON. EVEN IF I
LOSE.

Rohan read it over my shoulder.

“With ordinary cotton, Vikram’s going to cut us fast.”

“Then he’ll cut us.”

“You say that now.”

“I’m saying it because now I’ve seen it.”

He didn’t answer.

In bed, I kept thinking about the blue line. It was almost invisible. That was the worst part. Something could cross the whole sky, hurt a wing, and come right into our house without anyone seeing it coming.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

11

Not Your Hands

Thursday, January 9, 2025



Ma gave Agni back to me this morning.
“Until tonight,” she said. “Then you talk to your father.”

“What if he says no to the duel?”

“Maybe he will.”

“Then why let me practice?”

“Because learning and disobeying aren’t the same thing. You mix them up when it suits you.”

She had invited Aunt Kavita over for tea in the courtyard. That meant an adult would be within earshot during our session, even if Aunt Kavita thought she was only keeping an eye on the laundry.

Meena came with her string log. She still hadn’t forgiven me for lying about the fabric, but she had decided the wind

shouldn't have to pay for it.

Rohan had a plan ready.

GOAL: CUT A LINE WITH A KHEENCH
METHOD: FIVE FAST PULLS, THEN STEP BACK

"We're not cutting any lines today," I said.

"We'll practice with two cotton strings."

He had stretched a second line between two stakes, above the roof. No coating, no glass, no metal. Just white cotton.

"Vikram always attacks from underneath," he explained.

"You have to build up speed before he comes back up."

He put me in the middle of the stones and set my hands.

"When I say kheench, you do exactly five pulls."

"What if the wind shifts?"

"I'll see it."

"So will I."

"Not as fast."

Meena looked up from her phone.

"12 kilometers an hour, gusting to 15."

Rohan asked her to count.

I launched Agni. The ivory paper took the air easily. The little kesariya flame glowed in the middle without pulling the sail out of shape. We had finally built something that answered back.

"Duel position," Rohan said.

Meena tied the practice line above ours. I had to cross the two cotton strings, then pull fast enough to snap the one tied to the stakes.

“Kheench!”

I pulled five times.

The strings rubbed, but nothing broke. Agni lost height.

“Too slow,” Rohan said. “Again.”

We started over.

On the fourth try, I felt a gust coming from the right. It wasn't a thought. The tension changed against the inside of my first finger, and my right foot moved before Rohan said a word.

I gave some slack, let Agni slide sideways, then took the line back by twisting at the waist the way Ma had shown me.

The practice string snapped.

Meena let out a victory yell.

So did I.

Rohan didn't.

“That wasn't the move.”

“It worked.”

“By luck.”

“I felt the gust.”

“You left the angle we planned.”

“Because the wind left the angle we planned.”

He came over and grabbed the line with his left hand, behind my fingers.



“Do it again. Properly.”

Agni wobbled.

“Let go,” I said.

“Listen to me.”

“I’ve been listening to you for six days.”

“Six days, exactly. And you already think you know enough to make things up?”

I pulled my hand away. Rohan had to take the whole line with his left. His wrist bent under the pull.

“Give me the charkhi,” he ordered Meena.

“No,” she said.

“I know what I’m doing.”

“Your doctor told you not to strain it.”

“It’s not your hand.”

“That’s exactly the problem,” I said.

He looked at me.

“What?”

“From the very beginning, you’ve talked like I’m your hands. You say *we* when I get it right and *you* when I mess up.”

“Without me, you wouldn’t even know how to hold the string.”

“That’s true.”

He didn’t expect me to admit it.

“But just because you taught me doesn’t mean everything I do belongs to you.”

The wind pulled harder. Agni rose and dipped between us.

Rohan tightened his grip on the line.

“It’s my duel.”

“Then fly.”

I let go. Not of the line. I waited for Meena to take the charkhi, then passed the tension over to her the way Rohan had taught me. Only then did I step back.

“Ananya, come back.”

“No.”

“You can’t quit five days before Sankranti.”

“You took the line away from me after one second on the very first day.”

I went downstairs.

In the courtyard, Aunt Kavita was telling Ma that a neighbor had painted his house a pink “that looked like a sick shrimp.” They both went quiet when they saw me walk by.

“Practice over already?” Ma asked.

“Yes.”

“Will you talk to your father tonight?”

“Yes.”

I went into my room and shut the door.

An hour later, Rohan knocked our code.

I didn’t answer.

He knocked again.

I stayed sitting on my bed.

The third time, he didn’t use the code. He knocked once, very hard, and walked away.

Later, when I went to get some water, I saw him in the courtyard. He was doing his hand exercises. Lift the first finger. Hold for three seconds. Let go. His forehead was pressed against the wall.

On the fifth one, his fingers shook. He swore under his breath.

I almost stepped out of the shadows. I knew how to cheer him up: count for him, crack a joke, pretend not to notice his wet eyes.

I stayed where I was.

His pain made me want to open the door and fix everything. But if I went back only because he was hurting, our fight would disappear without ever being settled. I didn’t want to pretend.

I waited until he went back upstairs, then I left a bottle of water and his exercise sheet on the charpai. I didn’t leave a note.

Before bed, I went back down to check. The bottle was empty.

KNOT UNDONE TODAY: *The one that held our project together.*

I don't know if you can retie a knot in the same spot without making the string shorter.

CHAPTER TWELVE

12

Papa Counts the Rejects

Friday, January 10, 2025



I didn't talk to Papa on Thursday night.

He came home late with a bag of fabric over his shoulder and a migraine. I decided it would be better to wait until morning.

In the morning, he was getting ready for Mrs. Arora's visit. I decided to wait until after.

"After" came too fast.

Mrs. Arora owned a clothing boutique near Johari Bazaar. She wore glasses with green frames, and she always talked while looking past you, as if her appointments were lined up in front of her and she was already watching for the next one.

Papa laid the kesariya samples out on the big table.

I was helping Ma serve tea in the next room. I could hear their voices through the open door.

“Number 41 is too yellow,” Mrs. Arora was saying. “Number 42 loses its depth in the shade. You mentioned a test that came out uneven. Redder.”

The tray shook in my hands.

“Number 43,” Papa said. “One moment.”

I put the cups down and tried to slip up to my room. Ma blocked the way.

“Stay.”

Papa opened the sample drawer. Then the second one. The drawers banged. Boxes shifted.

“It was right here,” he said.

Mrs. Arora waited exactly thirty seconds before checking her phone.

Papa called us in.

Rohan came down first. I came in behind Ma. Meena was in the courtyard too. She had come to bring back my sound notebook, which I’d left at her house.

On the table, Papa had lined up the five squares that were left. He opened his black notebook to the page with the order.

“Number 43 is missing.”

Nobody answered.

“Ananya, you were in the workshop on January 2.”

The truth was ready. It only had one step to take.

“I only took some glue.”

One last lie.

I recognized it the second it left my mouth. It tasted like metal.

Papa put the notebook down.

"The glue wasn't in the workshop."

"I know. I got mixed up."

He turned to Rohan.

"Have you seen this sample?"

Rohan looked at his bandage.

"No."

His lie was shorter than mine. It hurt me more.

Meena held my notebook against her chest.

"I'm going to go home," she said.

"Wait," I whispered.

She didn't even shake her head. She just left.

Papa picked up each square, set it on the little scale, and checked the numbers in his notebook. Weighing them wasn't going to give him back the missing piece. It was his way of putting things back in order after someone had broken it.

Mrs. Arora appeared in the doorway.

"I have to leave in ten minutes."

Papa closed the notebook.

"I don't have 43 anymore. I can do another test today, but the result won't be the same."

"The presentation is Monday."

"I know."

"If I don't have approval today, I'll give the eight dupattas to another workshop."

Papa bowed his head.

"I understand."

She wasn't cruel, and she wasn't impatient. She had an order, a date, and no reason to pay for our secret.

After she left, Papa put the squares away one by one.

Ma went upstairs. She came back with Agni.

I think part of me still hoped she wouldn't put it together. Then she laid the kite on the table.

The kesariya flame had the number 43 in its bottom corner.

Papa didn't shout.

He touched the paper around the fabric, where the glue had stiffened the fibers.

"You cut it."

"It was crossed out."

"You read the line underneath."

I didn't answer.

"'Redo 43. Do not cut.' Did you read it?"

"Yes."

The word crossed the room all by itself.

Papa looked at Rohan.

"Did you know?"

Rohan didn't say anything.

"He didn't take anything," I said.

"That's not what I asked."

"Yes," Rohan murmured.

Papa untied the line from the bridle. He put the charkhi in his cupboard and turned the key.

"Agni stays here."

"It's my kite."

He looked up.

I shouldn't have said that.

"The paper, maybe. The bamboo, maybe. Not the color."

He pulled the key out of the lock.



"Mrs. Arora paid a deposit for eight pieces. If she takes back the order, I return her deposit and I'm stuck with everything I've already spent. That square wasn't trash. It was proof of the work that was done."

"I'm sorry."

"You got caught."

The difference hit me harder than yelling would have.

Ma closed her eyes for a second.

"You told me he gave it to you."

"I was going to give it back."

"Cut up?" she asked.

I had no sentences left.

Papa carried Agni into the workshop. The door scraped the floor, then closed.

At lunch, nobody touched the chapatis for several minutes.

Finally, Rohan said:

"I asked her to use the fabric."

"After she had already taken it," Papa said.

"I could have told her to put it back."

"Yes."

"I'll pay too."

"With what money?"

Rohan didn't have any savings left. His deposit was still sitting with the string seller. He looked down at his plate.

Papa didn't use that to embarrass him. He just let the question hang there.

Ma took away my phone and the key to the roof.

"Until we've decided what happens next," she said.

"Meena has to be able to call me about the homework."

“She can call my phone.”

I wanted to argue that the homework had nothing to do with the theft. Then I remembered how many times I had used the homework to hide it.

Papa took a bite.

“What we lose isn’t only the money for the fabric. Mrs. Arora was supposed to show the shade to her own customers. She gave them a date because she trusted mine. When I don’t keep my word, her work ends up late too.”

The consequences kept spreading. Folded up, the stolen square fit in my palm, and it had still reached people whose names I didn’t even know.

Rohan and I stayed in the courtyard.

“You could have said something,” I told him.

“So could you.”

“It was my stolen fabric, but it was our project.”

“You just said it was your kite.”

He was right, and I hated him for it.

I went out to find Meena. She was at the end of the lane, in front of Gopal Uncle’s shop.

“Wait.”

She turned around.

“I’m going to fix it.”

“Fix what? The fabric, the order, your father, your mother, or the lie you just told, again, right in front of me?”

“All of it.”

“You can’t say all of it when you haven’t picked a single thing to do yet.”

“I need you.”

“No. You need me to come back fast enough that you don’t have time to feel what you did.”

She handed me the sound notebook.

“Do something without an audience first.”

She left.

On the duel poster, Rohan’s name was still there. Someone had written FORFEIT? next to it in blue marker.

I thought about taking the marker and writing my name.

I didn’t add anything.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

13

A Debt of Color

Saturday, January 11, 2025



I started with twenty rupees.

They were at the bottom of my box, under a birthday card and two broken bangles. I put them on the workshop table at seven in the morning.

Papa was already working. He had on his gray apron. A pan of water was heating on a hot plate. Agni was leaning against the cupboard, out of my reach.

“This is for the fabric,” I said.

He looked at the bills.

“Keep them.”

“I want to pay you back.”

“You don’t know how much it is.”

“Then tell me.”

He finished weighing out a powder, then closed the jar.

"The square alone is worth more than twenty rupees. But you don't just owe me a square. I have to redo the tests and find the shade again. Last night, Mrs. Arora agreed to wait for a new sample. If she turns it down, the order goes somewhere else."

"Then I'll work."

"This isn't a game where one morning wipes everything out."

"I know."

"You didn't know it yesterday."

I made myself not answer back.

"I stole 43. I read the note. I told Rohan it was worthless when I knew that wasn't true. I lied to Meena, to Ma, and to you. Rohan found out after I took it. He helped me build the first Agni with it."

The last sentence cost the most. I wanted to protect my brother, and then I remembered the bird in the courtyard. Protecting someone doesn't mean throwing a blanket over every choice they make.

Papa washed his hands in a basin. The blue didn't come off.

"Why that color?"

"Because it failed."

"That's not a reason."

"Because you'd crossed it out. Because it was prettier than the others. Because it looked like a flame. Because I wanted something from the workshop that was mine."

He dried his hands.

"You wanted the color to give you a place."

"Maybe."

“A color taken in secret can’t prove you deserve to be seen.”

I stared at the blue stains on his fingers.

“And what if you’d never let me in here?”

Papa flinched, just barely.

“You come in when you’re looking for glue.”

“Exactly.”

The word came out louder than I meant it to.

“Rohan knows where the blades are, and the scales, and the notebooks. He knows the orders. All I know is where the glue is. And it isn’t even here.”

Papa looked around as if my words were showing him the workshop for the first time.

“That doesn’t excuse stealing,” I added.

“No.”

“But it’s still true.”

He pulled a stool out from under the table.

“Sit.”

He showed me his notes on kesariya 43. The first bath had come out too pale, too yellow. The next one had turned toward red. The client had loved the uneven depth and asked him to come close to it on eight dupattas, without needing them to match perfectly.

“A shade isn’t a magic recipe,” Papa said. “The fabric, the water, the temperature, and the time all change the result. Even the light changes what the eye thinks it sees.”

He put his finger on the word kesariya in the notebook.

“And a color also changes depending on where you put it. The same word can make people think of a spice, a festival outfit, a temple, a flag, or a song. It doesn’t mean the same

thing to everyone. In this workshop, you have to know what the client is asking for instead of deciding for her.”

“So what is Mrs. Arora asking for?”

“A warm color for a wedding collection. Not a religious symbol, and not a political one. It’s written in the order.”

I had only read the lines that suited me.

Papa showed me the references the printer in Sanganer had sent, the notes from the boutique, and the tests done here. Number 43 hadn’t come out of a single vat or a single family. It had passed through a whole chain of trades before it ended up under my sweater.

He took out two squares that looked the same to me.

“Which one is redder?”

I picked the one on the left.

“Go to the door.”

In the morning light, it was the one on the right.

“Number 43 was my memory,” he said. “Without it, I’m working from numbers and a photograph. It’s not the same thing.”

He handed me a stack of labels.

“If you want to make things right, start by writing the numbers without any mistakes.”

For two hours, I labeled samples. Papa handled the dye baths. I stayed away from the hot plate and the chemicals. I wrote down the time whenever he asked, rinsed only the little squares he dropped into a basin of clean water, and clipped them onto a low line with clothespins.



The work didn't look anything like the scene I had imagined. There was no moment when Papa told me I had talent. My numbers leaned. I switched 46 and 64. He had me redo the whole series to be sure.

At noon, Rohan came in.

He put an envelope on the table.

"The seller gave back part of the deposit," he said. "Farida Aunty came with me. He didn't want to, so she started talking really loud right in front of his shop."

Papa didn't touch the envelope.

"You went back there?"

"With her. And Ma knew."

"How much?"

Rohan told him. Papa wrote it in the black notebook on a new line: *Partial refund, banned string.*

"You'll help Ananya redo the sample inventory," Papa said.

"With one hand?"

"With your eyes. That's the part you two didn't use."

We worked side by side without talking. Rohan read out the numbers. I checked them off. When he read out 43, there was nothing to check.

By late afternoon, the sixth new test was drying by the door. Papa compared it to the photograph of 43, then called me over.

“Look at it outside, and then in here.”

The color changed between the shade of the workshop and the sun in the courtyard. It wasn't the same as the stolen piece. But it had the same warmth in the middle.

“That one,” I said.

“Why?”

“The red comes out when you take it outside. Mrs. Arora wanted the color to stay alive in the shade, but it has to work outdoors too.”

Papa set the sample aside.

He didn't say I was right. He didn't say I was wrong.

Before he closed up, Papa sent me to get the rest of the square from my box. I gave it back. Then he picked up Agni, still leaning against the cupboard. With warm water and a little spatula, we peeled the kesariya flame off the paper. The fibers were damaged. The number 43 could still be read in one corner.

Papa put it back with the other proof of the order.

Then he dug through a box and pulled out a scrap of pale orange fabric, stained where a print had slipped.

“This one came out of the inventory last month. Value in the shop: zero. Value as material: enough that we shouldn't waste it.”

He gave it to me.

"This doesn't mean I'm allowing the duel."

"I know."

"This doesn't mean the debt is paid."

"I know."

"And you're going to apologize to Meena without asking her to come back."

"I know."

He turned off the lamp.

Out in the courtyard, the orange scrap looked less beautiful than 43. Paler, not as deep, with a brown stain along one edge.

For the first time, I didn't ask it to give me a value it didn't have.

I just thought: this is what I'm actually allowed to use.

PAPA'S WORDS: *"A color taken in secret can't prove you deserve to be seen."*

MY WORDS: *It's annoying when Papa says something true right when I want him to be wrong.*

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

14

Vikram Without His Audience

Sunday, January 12, 2025



I apologized to Meena at her front door.

She was wearing an old green sweater and holding a colander full of broken gajak. Her mother was filling little bags of it for the family.

“I’m sorry I lied to you about what the fabric was worth,” I said. “I’m sorry I asked you to keep a secret without telling you the truth. I’m not asking you to come back.”

Meena waited for the rest.

“That’s it.”

“Did you practice?”

“Three times.”

“I can tell.”

She took a piece of gajak out of the colander and held it out to me.

“I’m not ready to go back up on the roof yet.”

“Okay.”

“But you can send me a picture of the new fabric.”

It was a crack in the door, not an open door. I said yes.

When I got home, Ma handed me a list for the market: kitchen string, sesame seeds, oil, and a box of tea. The lanes were packed with people getting ready. Speakers were testing songs on the rooftops. The shopfronts had disappeared behind stacks of patangs. The air smelled like toasted sugar, hot oil, and new paper.

I walked past Farida Patang House.

Vikram was inside, alone.

He wasn’t wearing his perfect uniform or the jacket with his school logo. He had on a gray sweatshirt with glue stains. He was sitting on the floor, replacing the bamboo stick in a blue and white patang.

His movements were precise. There was no shop assistant and no rich father holding the paper for him.

“Are you going to stand in the doorway all day?” he asked.

“I was watching how you set the stick.”

“Rohan didn’t show you?”

“He showed me his way.”

Vikram understood the difference.

“You two had a fight.”

“Does the whole neighborhood get a newsletter about us?”

“Gopal Uncle changed the question mark on the poster to two question marks.”

Farida Auntie wasn't at the counter. Someone was talking in the back room.

“Why are you fixing it here?” I asked.

“At my house, they're getting the roof ready for my father's guests. There are workers everywhere. Here, nobody moves my tools.”

His phone rang. PAPA lit up the screen. He answered.

“Yes... It's ready... No, I'm not using the old one... Yes, there'll be pictures... I know.”

He hung up and pressed down too hard on the stick. The paper cracked.



“Very precise,” I said.

“Shut up.”

Farida Auntie came out of the back room with two cups of tea.

“You can speak properly in my shop,” she told Vikram.

He looked down.

She examined the tear he had just made.

“You know exactly how much pressure this paper can take. Why did you force it?”

“The phone distracted me.”

“The phone didn’t have its hands on the stick.”

She gave him a little piece of repair paper, then turned to me.

“And you. Where’s your flame?”

“Confiscated.”

“Good reason?”

“Very good.”

I told her about the theft, the short version. She didn’t ask why Papa hadn’t punished me more. She only asked what I had given back and what was still left to fix.

Vikram listened while pretending to measure his stick.

“So you’re out,” he said.

“I didn’t say that.”

Farida Auntie glanced at his bag, which wasn’t zipped all the way, and then at his face.

“If you two go up the day after tomorrow, you both use ordinary cotton. A stronger string will never make up for a lack of skill.”

“My father already bought the spool,” Vikram said.

“A bad purchase doesn’t turn into a good decision just because it’s already paid for.”

Vikram zipped his bag shut.

So he had known what the choice was before I ever said a word. He couldn’t pretend nobody had warned him.

He set the damaged patang aside and took another one, a perfect one, out of a cloth cover.

“Your father wants pictures of the duel?”

“His company is paying for the decorations in the lane. He wants his name to show up when I win.”

“And if you don’t win?”

“I win.”

He said it without bragging. The way you’d say Tuesday comes after Monday.

“Rohan’s not flying,” he added. “They should take the poster down.”

“I can take his place.”

“I know.”

“Since when?”

“Since I saw you come out of Farida Aunty’s hugging a bunch of sticks like you’d stolen them. You’re bad at hiding things.”

“Not always, apparently.”

He tied the bridle on his patang.

“Can you actually fly?”

“Yes.”

“That’s not a beginner’s answer.”

“And what kind of string are you using?”

He froze.

One side pocket of his bag was still unzipped. Inside it, a spool of pale, almost transparent blue was shining.

The same blue as the line in the jasmine.

“Farida Aunty doesn’t sell that,” I said.

“I didn’t buy it here.”

“Rohan got eight stitches because of that string.”

“Rohan put his hand in the wrong place.”

“And the bird?”

Vikram frowned.

I told him about the bird that fell into our courtyard. Not to give him a lecture. I wanted to see if the picture could get into his head the way it had gotten into mine.

He looked at the spool.

“My father had it brought in,” he said. “He says everybody else uses it anyway.”

“And you?”

“Me what?”

“Can you fly without it?”

His eyes went hard.

“You think my gear wins for me?”

“No. I watched you fix that patang. You’re good.”

The compliment threw him more than an insult would have.

“Then don’t act like I’m scared of you.”

“I’m not.”

“Pull out of the duel. Gopal Uncle erases Rohan’s name. Next month, I’ll let you come to a practice on our roof. With normal string.”

He thought he was offering me something generous.

“You’ll let me?”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“It’s what you said.”

I turned toward the door.

“If you show up with cotton,” Vikram called after me, “don’t say I cheated when your line breaks.”

“If my line breaks, it breaks.”

“You say that now.”

Rohan had said the exact same words four days earlier.

I stopped.

“Yes,” I said. “Now that I’ve seen it.”

That evening, Ma lent me her phone for two minutes, timed. I sent Meena a picture of the new orange scrap.

She answered a minute later:

| *It's not as flashy.*

Then a second message:

| *I like it better.*

I think I do too.

PART FOUR

The Sky Keeps No Score



Chapters 15–18

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

15

The Knot That Holds

Monday, January 13, 2025



The day before Makar Sankranti, Jaipur runs out of room.

Patangs spill out of the shops. Charkhis pile up in front of doorways. Bags of gajak take over every table. The songs being tested on the rooftops come in through every window, each one louder than the last.

In our house, Agni lay in pieces on the workshop table.

Papa had given back the paper sail, the two sticks, and the bridle. He was keeping kesariya 43 with the samples for the order. The orange scrap I was allowed to use was waiting next to my scissors.

“You can fix the kite,” he had said. “My decision about the duel will come after.”

I had scraped off the old glue and straightened the bamboo crosspiece. The new flame would be smaller. Its brown stain would make a ragged edge, like smoke.

I had been working for twenty minutes when I heard our code on the workshop door.

One knock. A pause. Two knocks.

Rohan came in without waiting.

His bandage had been swapped for a lighter brace. He could move his first and middle fingers a little. The doctor had told him again not to carry anything and to keep doing his exercises.

"Does Papa know you're in here?" I asked.

"He sent me to sort the receipts."

"The receipts are on the other side."

"I got lost."

He sat down across from me. I kept cutting.

"The flame was better before," he said.

"The fabric was stolen before."

"I know."

I put down the scissors.

"What do you want?"

He pulled the crumpled score sheet out of his pocket. The columns of mistakes, minutes, and moves covered both sides. At the top, he had crossed out **ANANYA'S SCORE** and written **ANANYA'S FLIGHT LOG**.

"Pretty," I said. "Did you use a ruler?"

"I came to apologize."

I didn't say anything.

"I wanted to beat Vikram," he began. "When my hand got hurt, I thought that if you flew exactly like me, it would

be almost the same. I was giving you orders, and in my head, it was still my duel.”

“In your head, did I at least get to keep my own face?”

“Most of the time.”

I tried to stay mad. A smile slipped out, then disappeared.

“You lied to Papa when he asked about the fabric.”

“Yes.”

“You let me carry your secret about the string.”

“Yes.”

“You called my hands yours.”

He looked down at his hurt hand.

“That was the worst part.”

“The stealing was pretty bad too.”

“Okay. There are a lot of ‘worst’ parts.”

He slid the sheet over to me.

“If you fly tomorrow, I’ll hold the charkhi. But I’ll follow your signals.”

“And if I do a move that isn’t in your plan?”

“I’ll try to survive.”

“And if I lose?”

He took his time answering.

“Then it’ll be your loss.”

“Thanks a lot.”

“And if you win, it’ll be your win.”

That second sentence weighed more.

I put the sheet back down between us.

“I don’t know if Papa will let me enter.”

“Then we’ll give him reasons to say yes. Not lies.”

Meena showed up an hour later.

She was carrying her string log, two rolls of safety tape, and a box of gajak from her mother.

"I'm not coming back because everything's fine," she announced.

"Hi to you too."

"I'm coming back because tomorrow you two are going to do something with or without me, and without me, you'll forget to write down the wind speed."

Rohan raised his good hand.

"Objection."

"Overruled."

She looked over the orange scrap.

"Are you really allowed to use it?"

I called Papa.

He came to confirm it himself. Meena wrote in her log: Scrap no. 17. Out of inventory. Given by Mr. Sharma.

"You didn't have to write all that," I said.

"If someday you tell people it fell into your pocket all by itself, I'll have proof."

We glued on the new flame. It wasn't as dramatic as kesariya 43. It was more honest. I hadn't known a color could be honest.



While the glue dried, we worked out our safety plan on a big sheet of paper.

Meena wrote.

Rohan made suggestions.

Ma crossed out half of them.

Papa listened from the doorway.

SHARMA ROOF RULES

- 1 *Plain cotton only.*
- 2 *An adult stays with us from launch until landing.*
- 3 *Nobody goes closer than two big steps to the edge wall.*
- 4 *Closed shoes. Water. Bandages.*
- 5 *Nobody chases a kite into the street.*
- 6 *If a strange line touches our roof, nobody grabs it.*
- 7 *When someone says stop, everyone stops, even if the duel is almost won.*

Rohan added:

- 8 *The charkhi stays in the low crate when it spins fast. It must never roll loose on the roof.*

Papa brought a wooden crate lined with an old piece of cloth. The charkhi could spin in it without getting away. He also put a pair of safety scissors in a pocket attached to the outside.

“These are only for cutting our own cotton if the line gets dangerous,” he said. “Nobody cuts a tight line without knowing where it goes.”

Meena added a ninth rule:

- 9 *The number for the bird rescue line is posted by the stairs.*

Ma taped the sheet to the door to the roof.

“And the emergency signal?” Rohan asked.

We picked two words.

FULL DHEEL.

If I said them, Rohan had to put the charkhi in the crate and let the cotton run out without trying to save Agni. Papa would watch the spool. If the line didn't go slack, he would cut our side with the scissors.

"The patang could fly off with the whole line," Rohan said.

"I know."

"We might never find it."

I looked at the new flame.

"Then we won't find it."

By four o'clock, the glue was dry. We all went up to the roof together. Papa stood by the stairs. Ma stayed behind me. Meena announced a moderate west wind. Rohan set the charkhi in its crate.

"You're launching," he said.

"And who's on the line?"

"You are. That too."

Launching alone means holding the patang up against the wind, backing up without losing the angle, then catching the line at just the right moment. On our small roof, we used a very short launch cord and kept the middle clear.

I lifted Agni.

The paper trembled. The orange flame filled out for a second, then went flat.

"Wait for the gust," Rohan said.

Then he corrected himself:

"I mean... if you want."

I waited.

The wind came in across my left cheek. I stepped forward, let go of Agni, and took the line back. The patang slid

up above us.

“Dheel,” I said.

Rohan let out some string.

“More. Hold it there. Short kheench.”

This time, he was the one following my words.

Agni climbed. The brown stain along the edge of the flame really did look like smoke.

I tried my diagonal. Right foot, waist, slack, take it back. Agni crossed the wind without diving.

Rohan whistled through his teeth.

“That wasn’t luck,” he admitted.

“I’m writing down the date for that too,” Meena said.

After ten minutes, Ma shouted:

“Stop!”

Without asking why, I quit pulling. Rohan gently held the spool still. Papa stepped forward.

Ma had only seen a sandal left by the stairs and thought a little kid was coming up. Nobody appeared.

“Good test,” she said.

We brought Agni down.

Papa looked it over, then read our nine rules. His finger stopped on *plain cotton* and on *full dheel*.

“Gopal Uncle needs permission from the family,” I said.

“I know.”

“And an adult on the roof.”

“I know that too.”

The sun was sinking behind the houses. The pink walls were turning a cooler color. All around us, families were testing their patangs. We could already hear shouts of *Woh kaata!* from practice duels.

Papa looked at my mother.

She said:

“If she doesn’t fly tomorrow, she’ll keep learning anyway. The question isn’t whether we can put this idea back in a box anymore.”

Papa looked at Rohan.

“She flies better than I do with one hand,” my brother said.

“That’s not a very high bar,” I muttered.

“She flies well,” he corrected himself.

Papa turned to Meena.

“And you?”

“She still pulls too hard when she’s scared. But she listens when I call out danger. Today, anyway.”

“Thanks for that last part.”

Papa picked up the sheet of rules.

“You’ll fly under your own name. Not Rohan’s. If I see a dangerous line, the duel stops. If anyone refuses, you come down. And after winter break, you’ll work in the workshop until the order is finished, duel or no duel.”

“Yes.”

“And I’ll be on the roof.”

I think that condition scared him as much as it scared me.

We all went to Gopal Uncle’s shop together. He took out his marker and crossed out Rohan’s first name on the poster. My brother asked for the marker.

He wrote ANANYA above our last name.

Not squeezed in under his.

At the same height as VIKRAM MEHTA.

The Joshi brothers watched. One of them shrugged. The other asked if he could still bet chips.

The world didn't stop.

But my name stayed on the wall.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

16

A Thousand Roofs

Tuesday, January 14, 2025 (Morning)



At 6:10, Ma lit the puja lamp.

At 6:20, she yelled because the milk was boiling over.

At 6:22, Rohan announced it wasn't his fault.

At 6:23, nobody believed him.

That's how Makar Sankranti began.

The house smelled like tea, toasted sesame, and the oil for the pakode. Ma had made til ke laddu the night before. Aunt Kavita was bringing feeni. Gopal Uncle had promised gajak, which mostly meant he would come over and eat ours.

I slept for three hours.

Agni was resting on top of the cupboard, out of the cat's reach. The ivory paper was perfect. In the lamplight, the

flame I was allowed to use looked almost red.

Papa came in with two pairs of clear safety glasses.

“For you and Rohan.”

“Are glasses in our rules?”

“They are now.”

He also put some gardening gloves by the stairs, for the adults who would pick up the trash after the festival. Never for flying.

Rohan checked the charkhi three times. The spool held only plain cotton from Farida Aunty’s shop. He had marked the last few meters in red so we would know when the line was running out.

“Did you sleep?” I asked him.

“Perfectly.”

“You retied the knot at 4:17.”

“How do you know?”

“The wall between our rooms is just for decoration.”

At eight, we went up.

The cold was still sitting in the stones. In the pale sky, about ten patangs were already flying. Then twenty. Then so many I gave up counting. Above them, black kites, the real birds, were circling in wide loops like every morning. Today, they had a lot less room.

The whole neighborhood seemed to have moved its living room up to the roof. Grandparents settled into chairs. Kids ran only in the clear areas and got called back the second they went near an edge. Women handed out tea, then took their turn on the line. The Bansal twins were flying a pink patang together while their cousin held the charkhi.

Meena bumped me with her shoulder.

“Look at that. The sky didn’t fall.”

“Are you going to keep saying that for the rest of my life?”

“Only when you forget your roof isn’t the whole city.”

The speakers started before nine. One song came from the Joshis’ roof, another from a modern building farther off. They didn’t keep the same beat. Shouts of *Woh kaata!* burst out in between. Every time a cut patang drifted down toward the lanes, the kids followed it with their eyes, but the adults on our street had banned running in the road.

Papa reread the rules posted by the stairs. He was wearing a clean shirt, but the blue was still around his fingernails.

We waited until nine before taking out our first patang.

“We start with the green one,” Papa said.

“That was my idea,” I said.

“Good.”

The green one was an ordinary patang from Handipura. Rohan held it up while I took the line.

“Ready?”

I checked my feet, my taped fingers, and where Meena was standing. Ma was by the stairs. Papa was guarding the charkhi crate.

“Launch.”

The green patang caught the wind on the second try. I took it up to a sensible height, without going near the fighting lines yet.

Rohan was waiting for my orders.

“Dheel. Hold it there. Three turns. Short kheench.”

The charkhi spun in its crate. The wood made a sound like a dry purr.

On the next roof, an old woman raised her glass of tea at me.

“Good hands!” she called.

I almost lost my angle answering her.

“Watch your patang,” Ma said.

At 9:30, a gust pushed the green one toward a TV antenna. I felt the pull slide along the side of my first finger. Instead of yanking, I moved my right foot and let out a short length of string. The patang went around the antenna.

Papa followed the move without a word.

At ten, I brought the green one down in one piece.

First flight: no accident, no win, no story to tell.

It was exactly what I needed.

Ma held out her hand.

“My turn.”

Rohan and I stared at her.

“Gopal Uncle told me you used to fly,” I said.

“Gopal Uncle should sell more biscuits and fewer memories.”

We launched the green patang again. Ma took the line.

I was expecting to have to show her where to put her fingers. She tested the tension, stepped her left foot forward, and gave just enough slack for the green patang to catch a higher current. Her wrists weren't fast, but her feet found every foothold before the wind could move her.

“You really know how to fly.”

“I knew how to keep it up. My cousin flew the duels.”

“Why don’t you fly anymore?”

“Because when you spend enough years cooking for twenty people, sometimes you end up staying by the stairs.”

She looked at Rohan.

“And because certain people used to take the line before I even asked for it.”

Rohan suddenly got very interested in the spool.

Ma kept the patang up for five minutes. She wasn’t going for height or looking for an opponent. She was just following the wind. Her face had changed. Not younger, not transformed. Just free, for a little while, of the next cup to pour and the next pot to watch.

Papa brought her tea instead of calling her down.

“Dheel,” she ordered him.

He obeyed.

I had never seen my parents like that. Maybe they hadn’t seen themselves like that in a long time either.

When Ma handed the line back to me, she was breathing faster.

“Don’t write in your journal that I was amazing.”

“Why not?”

“Because I didn’t cut anything, and that suited me just fine.”

I promised not to write *amazing*.

I didn’t promise anything about the rest.

We ate gajak sitting far away from the edge. The sugar stuck to our teeth. Gopal Uncle came up with his score notebook under his arm and two pockets already full of our pakode.





“The main duel will be at three,” he announced. “The wind will be better.”

“Who decided that?” Meena asked.

“Experience.”

“The weather app says 2:40.”

“Experience rounds up.”

The Joshi brothers challenged the Bansal twins. Nobody thought it was strange that the girls were flying. Everybody thought it was strange that they won in under four minutes. Their cousin shouted *Woh kaata!* louder than they did.

“See?” Meena said.

“Yes, yes. My roof isn’t the city.”

“I meant: their cousin is really good at holding the spool.”

Around eleven, my first opponent showed up. Aarav Joshi, the younger of the two brothers, had lost a bet against his own better judgment and wanted to win back his honor.

“Cotton duel,” Gopal Uncle declared. “No coating. We stop if the lines drop below the roofs.”

Papa inspected both spools. Aarav’s father did the same.

I picked Agni.

When I held it up, several people recognized the flame. A murmur went around, but it didn’t turn into a big silence. A little girl was begging for a laddu. Somebody’s uncle was turning up the volume on a song. Two patangs had just been cut farther away. The city had better things to do than hold its breath for me.

Rohan launched Agni.

The ivory patang went up so easily it almost offended me. All those fights, all that glue, all those lies, just to find out the paper only wanted some air.

Aarav crossed his line over mine. He liked the kheench: fast pulls, one after another, without much slack. Rohan had explained that style to me. I listened to the rubbing in my fingers.

“He’s pulling,” Rohan whispered.

“I know.”

“Sorry.”

I waited for Aarav to speed up. Then I used my diagonal: right foot, waist, short dheel. Agni slid under his line. Before he could adjust, I took the cotton back in two clean pulls.

Aarav’s line broke.

His yellow patang drifted off to the west.

“WOH KAATA!”

The shout exploded from our roof, then from the Bansals’. Rohan raised his good hand. Meena jumped up and down before she remembered she was holding the log. Ma squeezed my shoulder.

Papa was watching the string.

“Bring Agni in cleanly,” he said.

I did. One win didn’t cancel out the next wind.

Once Agni was down, Papa checked the bridle and the spot where the cotton had rubbed.

“You changed your angle before you pulled,” he said.

“My diagonal.”

“Rohan taught you that?”

“No. He thought it was a mistake.”

Rohan raised a hand.

“Old opinion officially withdrawn.”

Papa turned Agni in the light.

“In the workshop, if a method keeps giving you the same wrong color, you don’t pull harder on the recipe.”

“You can’t pull on a recipe.”

“You understand.”

He put Agni back in my hands. It was the first time he had talked about the way I fly as a technique, and not a whim.

Right then, I understood something I hadn’t wanted to admit: I already had the proof I’d been looking for. I had flown under my own name and chosen my own move, and it had worked in front of the same people who, two weeks earlier, had only ever seen me behind the charkhi.

I didn’t need the duel with Vikram to prove I could fly anymore.

I still wanted it.

At noon, his roof filled up.

It was on the new building across the lane, under a white shade canopy. A banner with the name of his father’s company was tied to the wall. Guests were taking pictures. His father was shaking hands.

Vikram was wearing the gray sweatshirt with the glue stains instead of the new clothes I’d imagined. He launched a blue and white patang, cut two lines in less than ten minutes, and brought his own back without a single crease.

He was excellent.

Rohan watched him with his old expression, the one that turned everything Vikram did into a personal insult.

Then he looked down at the charkhi.

"He always attacks from underneath," he said.

"I know."

"I'm giving you information. Not an order."

"Then I'll take it."

Ma served us dal baati in bowls. I was too scared to be hungry, but she made me eat half.

"An empty body makes bad decisions," she said.

"A full body might throw up on the roof."

"Half, then."

At 2:30, Meena checked her app.

"West wind, 17 kilometers an hour, gusting to 22."

Papa checked the roof one last time. He sent the little cousins who had come to watch back downstairs. Aunt Kavita settled them in the courtyard, where they would follow the duel with a mirror and way too many comments.

At three, Gopal Uncle opened his notebook.

"Ananya Sharma against Vikram Mehta. Plain cotton on both sides."

On the roof across the way, Vikram's father gave a thumbs up.

Vikram didn't move.

I showed him my spool.

He showed me his, partly hidden in a black crate.

From that far away, the string looked pale.

Almost transparent.

Rohan saw it the same moment I did.

"Anu," he murmured.

I could already feel the memory of the blue filament in my palm.

Gopal Uncle raised his hand to start the duel.

WIND REPORT

- *Direction: west.*
- *Strength: enough to carry Agni, and enough to carry a bad decision a very long way.*
- *State of my hands: protected.*
- *State of my head: a lot less.*

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

17

The Forbidden Line

Tuesday, January 14, 2025 (Afternoon)



Gopal Uncle dropped his hand.
Rohan launched Agni.

Vikram launched his blue and white patang.

For the first few seconds, there wasn't any duel. There were just two pieces of paper above the lane, each looking for its wind.

"Dheel," I said.

The charkhi spun in its crate. Rohan let the cotton out in steady lengths. Across the way, Vikram was raising his patang with short pulls. His helper, a cousin I didn't know, was handling the black spool.

Papa was watching their string.

"The part near the spool looks like cotton," he said quietly. "I can't see what's already out."

"Do we stop?" Ma asked.

Rule number seven was taped up behind her.

When someone says stop, everyone stops.

Nobody had said the word yet.

"I'm watching it," I said.

That was my first bad decision of the afternoon. Not the worst. The first.

The patangs reached the same height. Gopal Uncle shouted that the duel could begin. All around us, the talking moved closer. Phones went up. Vikram's father stood under his company's banner, one hand on a guest's shoulder.

Vikram attacked right away.

His line slid under mine. Agni shook.

"He's setting up a kheench," Rohan whispered.

I could feel it. The vibration in my fingers was getting faster and more even. Vikram was looking for the right angle to come up pulling.

Instead of backing up, I stepped my left foot forward. I gave slack before he could attack. Agni dropped a meter, slipped past his line, and caught the wind lower down.

Vikram had to adjust.

A shout ran across the rooftops.

"Nice," Rohan said.

I didn't need him to say it. I was glad he did.

Vikram brought his patang back up over mine. He was patient. Every time I changed my angle, he waited instead of chasing me. He didn't fly like a rich boy who had bought

his win. He flew like someone who had spent hundreds of hours with a string between his fingers.

That made the duel better.

And it made his choice to cheat even worse.

Our lines crossed for the first time. Our cotton scraped against the other string. The sound was too high.

Rohan heard it.

“That’s not cotton up there.”

“I hear it.”

“Stop,” Ma said.

The word was clear.

I should have brought Agni in.

At that exact moment, a gust pushed Vikram’s patang to the left. His line ended up under mine. I had the advantage. Two fast pulls could force him down. Maybe three.

“One second,” I answered.

Second bad decision.

I pulled.

Agni took the angle. The orange flame tilted toward the blue and white patang. Vikram backed off. His helper let out several meters.

A length of line that had been hidden in the shadow of the crate came out into the sun.

The string flashed blue.

Almost transparent.

What we had taken from far away for very pale cotton was the synthetic filament I’d seen in his bag.

Papa took a step toward the edge wall, then stopped at the line marked on the floor.

“This duel is over!” he shouted.

Gopal Uncle raised both arms.

“Stop! Bring in your lines!”

Vikram’s father protested from the other roof.

“It’s an approved string!”

Farida Aunty, who was watching from Gopal Uncle’s roof, shouted something back that the music drowned out. Her face said enough.

Vikram didn’t bring his patang in.

He pulled.

Maybe he hadn’t heard. Maybe he had chosen not to hear. His synthetic line rubbed against our cotton. A gray mark appeared on the string between my fingers.

“Let the angle go,” Rohan said. “We’re taking it down.”

I knew he was right.

But Vikram’s line was still under mine. If he pulled again, he would come up and cut me. If I did my diagonal now, I still imagined I could break his line.

A chance to win.

I moved my right foot.

“Ananya, no,” Meena said.

Third bad decision: I didn’t stop.

I gave a little slack.

Agni slid sideways. The wind filled its sail. The tension came back into my fingers, perfect and clean, exactly what I’d been waiting for.

“Now!” Rohan yelled.

His old reflex had done the talking.

Kheench.

I started to pull.

A beating of wings cut through the shouting.

Meena saw it first.

“Bird!”

A black kite was coming down between the patangs. It must have been riding a warm current over the houses. Its right wing touched the blue filament.

It all happened too fast, and I still saw every detail.

The wing folded.

The bird spun.

Vikram’s line wrapped around its feathers, then caught on the bar of an antenna on a lower roof. For a moment, the bird hung above the wall, beating its free wing.

Two little kids were on that roof. Their grandmother pulled them toward the stairs.

“Everybody back!” Ma shouted.

Papa grabbed his phone and gave our address to the rescue line. Farida Aunty was already calling from the other roof.

The blue filament ran from Vikram’s patang to the bird, then back to where it crossed my line.

Every pull tightened the loop around the wing.

And my hand was ready to pull.

If I did a kheench, maybe his line would break.

His patang would fly away.

Gopal Uncle might write down my name.

The bird would pay for my move.

On the roof across the way, Vikram was still holding his line. His face had changed. He was looking at the bird, not at his patang.

His father was shouting something at him.

Rohan was shouting too.

“Dheel! Dheel, Anu!”

He had changed his first order. This time, I heard him.

I opened my fingers just enough to let the cotton slide over the tape on my palm.

The tension dropped, then came back when the wind caught Agni.

I could still stop the line. I could still save the kite, and maybe the duel.

I looked at the orange flame.

It wasn't the stolen kesariya, and it didn't have to prove anything. It was a scrap I was allowed to use, on a kite we had fixed together.

That was why losing it hurt.

“Full dheel!” I shouted.

Rohan let the charkhi spin in the crate. Papa took his hands off the spool so it could spin without dragging anyone. Meena backed up to the marked area. Ma checked the stairs.

The wood started to rattle in the crate.

The cotton was running out so fast that the red marks showed up almost right away.

“End of the line!” Rohan called.

His eyes were on me.

The last loop was coming up to the axle. All he had to do was stop the charkhi.

He didn't.

The last loop slipped off the wood.

Agni was free.

With nothing pulling back against it, Vikram's filament sagged in the air. The loop around the bird loosened a little.

On the lower roof, the grandmother had taken the children inside. A man came out with a blanket, but Papa yelled at him to wait for the rescuers and not to grab the line.

Vikram finally put his spool down in the crate.

His father tried to take the charkhi.

Vikram pushed him away with his elbow.

“Don’t pull!”

Following instructions that Farida Aunty shouted across, an adult on their roof put on gloves and used safety scissors to cut their line near the spool. The filament dropped onto the roof instead of staying stretched tight between the houses.

“Don’t touch it!” Farida Aunty shouted.

Vikram stepped back.

His blue and white patang flew off in the opposite direction from Agni.

For a few seconds, both kites flew without us.

His came down behind the new building.

Agni went up.

A gust flipped it over. The flame disappeared, then came back. The cotton string trailed behind it like a pale thread. Agni crossed the first rooftops, passed the Mehta company banner, and kept going north.

I watched it until it was an ivory dot.

Then nothing.

My hands were empty.

The silence didn’t last. In a city full of music, shouting, and hundreds of duels, no silence lasts very long.

“Who won?” somebody asked.

“She let go!”





“So did he!”

“The duel was already stopped!”

“Did you see the blue string?”

Gopal Uncle closed his notebook.

“No score,” he announced. “Safety incident.”

I had thought losing would make a particular sound. Maybe other people shouting, maybe a line snapping.

Really, it sounded like a charkhi that had stopped spinning.

Two rescuers came through the house next door. They were the same volunteers as the week before. We stayed on our roof while they covered the bird, loosened the filament, and freed its wing with their tools.

I couldn't see the injury. That was fine with me.

The woman gave a thumbs up when they put the bird in a box.

“Alive,” Ma told us. “They're taking it to the center.”

My knees gave out. I sat down in the middle of the roof.

Rohan crouched next to me.

“I yelled kheench,” he said.

“I know.”

“Then I saw.”

“So did I. I kept going after I saw the string.”

“For a few seconds.”

“Long enough to be a choice.”

He didn't try to comfort me with a lie.

Meena sat down on my other side. She put her log between us, open to a blank page.

“Time of the incident?” I asked.

“3:17.”

“Write it down.”

She wrote down the time, the wind direction, the color of the filament, and the number we had called.

On the last line, she asked:

“Result of the duel?”

I looked at the part of the sky where Agni wasn’t anymore.

“None.”

Then I added:

“No. Write stopped.”

It wasn’t the same thing.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

18

The True Color

Tuesday, January 14, 2025 (Evening)



Before we even got back downstairs, three people had already told a story that wasn't true.

In the first one, I had cut Vikram's line and then given up my win to save a bird.

In the second, I had flown Agni around the bird on purpose to hold it up.

In the third, the most amazing one, I had jumped from one roof to another with a pair of scissors.

I hadn't done any of that.

A boy of about sixteen was filming from the Joshis' roof. He pointed his phone at me.

"Tell us how you saved the bird."

"The rescuers saved it."

"But you let go of your kite."

“Yes.”

“Because you knew right away what to do?”

I thought about the seconds when I had kept going. About rule number seven. About the word stop, which Ma had said and I had ignored.

“No,” I said. “First, I tried to win.”

The boy lowered his phone a little.

On the roof across the way, some adults were talking around the black crate. Farida Auntie had gone over there with Gopal Uncle. She was wearing thick gloves. With Papa and Vikram’s father, she was looking only at the part of the line they could reach, which was slack now and lying on the ground. Nobody touched it with bare hands.

Vikram was standing off to one side.

“It’s imported nylon,” his father was saying. “It’s not coated manjha.”

“Synthetic line is exactly what’s banned,” Farida Auntie answered. “Look at what it just did.”

“All the boys use it.”

“Not on my roof,” Gopal Uncle said.

“Your roof isn’t the whole city.”

I knew that sentence.

Gopal Uncle snapped his notebook shut right under the man’s nose.

“No. But I decide what goes in my notebook.”

The boy was still filming. The neighbors were waiting for a statement. I could feel a story building itself around me, prettier and simpler than what had really happened.

I could have let it.

If I kept quiet, I was the girl who had flown a flame, stood up to the champion, and saved a bird. Nobody needed to know about the stolen square, the order we almost lost, or how many times Meena had asked me for the truth.

The wind lifted the corner of the rules sheet behind Ma.

Personal doesn't mean perfect. Personal means honest.

Mrs. Patel's words came back at the worst possible time.

"At first, Agni had a piece of fabric on it that I stole from my father's workshop," I said.

Rohan turned his head toward me.

The phone came closer.

"What?" the boy asked.

"I thought it was a reject. Then I read that Papa needed it, and I took it anyway. He lost time, and he almost lost an order. The fabric that flew away today was a different piece. He gave it to me after I confessed and started making things right."

The neighbors didn't react the way they did in my nightmares. Some of them looked surprised. Others didn't understand why I was talking about fabric when a bird had just been carried off in a box.

I kept going because Rohan was standing next to me.

"My brother went looking for banned strings before the festival too. That's how he got hurt. He didn't use it today, but we hid it."

Rohan stepped forward.

"It's true," he said. "It was my choice. Ananya kept the secret because I asked her to."

"And I said yes," I added.

The boy looked at his screen.

“That’s a lot less clear, as stories go.”

“Yes.”

He stopped filming.

Vikram had heard. He crossed his roof to the edge wall, without going past the mark his own father had painted on the floor.

“The blue string was mine,” he shouted.

His father spun around.

“Vikram, be quiet.”

“You bought it, but I knew it wasn’t cotton. I said it was so I could fly.”

His voice wasn’t loud. The lane heard it anyway.

“You wanted me to win,” he said to his father. “So did I.”

He didn’t apologize to the bird. He didn’t ask us to forgive him. He just stopped handing his choice over to someone else.

Gopal Uncle opened his notebook again. On the page for the duel, he wrote in big letters:

STOPPED. BANNED STRING. NO WINNER.

Vikram’s father took down his company’s banner before dark.

That didn’t change the city. Dangerous lines were still flying in other places. Sirens kept going in the streets. The rescue center kept getting more birds. On some roofs, people were probably using the same spools and pretending they didn’t know.

But in our lane, Farida Aunty and Gopal Uncle set new conditions. From now on, duels would use only plain

cotton, either from a shop that had signed up or brought in its sealed package. One adult from each roof would sign the notebook. The rescue numbers would stay posted.

“That won’t stop every lie,” Meena said.

“No,” Farida Aunty answered. “But rules are also there to make lying harder.”

When the sun went down, the patangs made way for lights. Kandeels floated up over the houses. Fireworks burst near Jal Mahal and farther off across the city. I should have thought it was beautiful.

I kept looking for Agni in every orange dot.

Ma handed me a cup of tea.

“You might not find it.”

“I know.”

“You made the right choice, in the end.”

“Only in the end.”

“That’s often where a choice matters most.”

I wasn’t ready to turn the day into a lesson. I had lost Agni. The bird was hurt. I had ignored Ma’s signal and kept going after I recognized the string. All of that was still true, right alongside the last thing I did.

We cleaned the roof before it got completely dark. Wearing the gloves, the adults took down the pieces they could reach. The kids picked up only paper and wrappers in the safe area. Any line nobody recognized was reported and left for the adults.

Rohan found the score sheet under the crate. He turned it over and wrote:

ANANYA SHARMA: 1 WIN, 1 DUEL STOPPED

Then, underneath:

ROHAN SHARMA: CHARKHI

“You could write assistant,” I suggested.

“Absolutely not.”

“You were good at it, though.”

“Don’t start.”

He folded the sheet and gave it back to me.

Wednesday, January 15, 2025

This morning, Papa got a message from Mrs. Arora.

She was accepting the new sample. The order would stay with us, two days late and at a lower price. The debt hadn’t disappeared. It had only stopped growing.

After breakfast, Papa called me into the workshop.

“Yesterday, up on the roof, you talked about the workshop,” he said.

“I wanted to tell the truth.”

“Your truth belonged to you. My order didn’t. Mrs. Arora could have learned the details of the theft from a video before I told her.”

I hadn’t thought about her. I had only thought about not lying anymore.

“Next time, ask me before you tell me something that’s mine.”

“And if you say no?”

“Then you tell only your part.”

On the table were three squares that were almost the same, and a long pair of wooden tongs.

"These are for lifting the little samples out of the clean water without wrinkling them," he said. "Not out of the dye baths. Only for rinsing, when I ask you."

He handed me the tongs.

They weren't a trophy. They were worn from use and had a small burn mark on the handle.

"Take 51. Look at it at the door, in the courtyard, and under the lamp. Write down what changes."

"Now?"

"The light isn't going to wait for you."

I picked up the square with the tongs. In the workshop, it looked orange. At the door, the red came up. In the courtyard, next to the pink wall, a brownish shade showed along the edge.

Papa listened to what I'd noticed without smiling.

"Tomorrow, seven o'clock," he said. "We'll check all eight pieces before delivery."

"Am I still being punished?"

"Yes."

"And you're going to teach me anyway?"

"I can do both."

That was Rohan's line. I wondered which of them had stolen it from the other.

That afternoon, we searched the streets around us for Agni. All we found was a piece of ivory paper caught on a gate. It didn't have the flame or our writing on it. It could have come from any patang.

I left it there.

ROOF INVENTORY AFTER THE FESTIVAL:

- *seven triangles of paper*
- *two empty gajak bags*
- *one gray feather, handed over to the rescuers*
- *four pieces of plain cotton, wound around cardboard*
- *one unknown line near an antenna, reported*
- *Rohan's score sheet*
- *an empty spot by the wall where Agni used to dry*

COLOR OF THE DAY: *none.*

Some things go missing before you know what to call them.

EPILOGUE

The Next Wind

Wednesday, January 29, 2025



Mrs. Patel gave our journals back today. In the end, I had put stars on for six days. Not on the theft. Not on the bird. Not on the duel. I had starred the first day, the first flight that worked, the failure of the first Agni, the work in the workshop, and two pages about Meena.

The night before I turned in the notebook, I added a note:

You can read all of it, as long as you keep to yourself anything that doesn't belong to the class.

I didn't know if a teacher could sign that kind of contract. Mrs. Patel wrote underneath:

Agreed. Other people's stories stay theirs.

She didn't correct a single one of my sentences. In the margin of the duel day, she only drew a little circle around the word *stopped* and wrote:

You chose the exact word.

After class, she asked me why I had decided to let her read the pages without stars after all.

"People were already telling the story," I said. "I wanted at least one person to read the one where I don't win all the time."

"A journal doesn't have to correct rumors."

"I know."

"It can also keep some things just for you."

I thought about Ma wanting to dance, about Rohan's shaking fingers against the wall, and about Papa's face when the order almost went somewhere else. I hadn't written down all of it. Even honesty has doors.

"I kept back what wasn't only mine," I answered.

Mrs. Patel nodded.

"That's a good reason to leave a page blank."

At recess, Meena wanted to see.

"Did she read the page where you say I take pictures of everything?"

"Yes."

"And the one where you say I crush flowers into dust?"

"Yes."

"Your teacher now has a very worrying picture of me."

"She thinks you're methodical."

Meena accepted that word.

Our friendship didn't go back to being exactly the way it was. Maybe it's stronger in some places and easier to see in others, like a mended patang where you can still see the patch.

She still keeps the string log. Gopal Uncle has a copy of it in his shop now. Last weekend, six families cleaned the roofs along our lane. The adults took down the strings with gloves and tools. We sorted the paper and the cardboard. We filled three bags.

Three bags in a whole city is almost nothing.

It's also three bags that aren't on our roofs anymore.

The bird from our courtyard is getting better at the center. The one from the duel survived too, but nobody knows yet if it will be able to fly normally. Meena calls once a week. She asks so many questions that the volunteer recognizes her voice.

Rohan goes to his sessions for his hand. He can bend three fingers halfway now. The doctor says his strength will come back slowly if he does his exercises and doesn't try to be a hero too soon.

That last part was meant for Rohan in particular.

He hasn't gone back to flying. Sometimes he holds the charkhi for me on the roof, when Ma or Papa is there. The first time, he gave me an order without thinking.

I turned around.

He said:

"Sorry. Information: the gust is coming from the right."

I answered:

"Information received."

We're working out a language.

Vikram didn't become our friend.

His father tried to get the video taken down, but the boy who filmed it had already shared a cut version with the neighborhood group. It showed my full dheel, not my confession. At first, I wanted him to post the rest too. Papa asked me what strangers needed to know about our workshop. I couldn't come up with an answer. Ma called the boy's mother, and the video disappeared from the neighborhood group.

Vikram is banned from duels in our lane until next season. He still comes to Farida Auntie's anyway. On Saturday, I ran into him there with a spool of plain cotton.

"Your diagonal works better when you wait half a second longer before you take the line back," he said.

"I know."

"No, you still take it back too early."

"And you still hide your compliments inside your criticism."

He didn't answer. It wasn't a friendship. It wasn't exactly a war anymore either.

In the workshop, Mrs. Arora's order is finished. The eight dupattas aren't all the same shade. But they belong to the same family of color. Papa taught me to look at them in three kinds of light and write down the differences without writing *better* or *worse*.

"Describe before you judge," he says.

That rule works for way too many things.

Today, after school, I found a new charkhi on the back shelf.

It's smaller than Rohan's. The wood is light. The handles don't have any initials.

"Is it for an order?" I asked.

Papa was checking a dye bath. He didn't look up.

"No."

"Then who's it for?"

"Someone who'll know to keep it in the crate when the line spins too fast."

I picked it up. The axle turned without catching.

"How many more days do I have to work for the fabric?"

"For the fabric? You're done. The order's been delivered."

"Can I still come back?"

"Tomorrow, after school, if you want to learn."

I put the charkhi back down.

Rohan appeared in the doorway with his exercise sheet under his arm.

"Does it spin okay?"

"You knew it was here?"

"I sanded one of the handles. With my left hand. Papa had to redo half of it."

He took out a pencil and looked at the light wood.

"Want me to write your initials?"

"Why you?"

"Because I wrote mine on the first one."

"Exactly."

I took the pencil from him. Instead of marking the handle, I wrote A. S. on a little paper tag and tied it around the axle. The wood would stay bare until I knew how I wanted to carve it.

Rohan spun the spool.

“Your tag’s going to tear the first time you practice.”

“Then I’ll write another one.”

“That’s not very permanent.”

“I don’t need everything to be permanent today.”

He nodded. On his old charkhi, his carved initials were deep and uneven. On mine, two paper letters fluttered in the draft from the door.

Both were real.

By the door, a draft lifted the corner of a kesariya sample. The fabric shivered, ready to slide off the table.

The first time, I would have taken it.

This time, I set the wooden tongs on its edge and called Papa.

“Come look. The color changes in the wind.”

He came over.

We looked at it together.



Words from the Lane



Aunty, Uncle: in India, a warm and respectful way to address an older woman or man, even someone who isn't family.

Chapati: a round, flat bread made from wheat flour, cooked without yeast.

Charkhi: a wooden spool that holds the kite string.

Charpai: a traditional bed made of a wooden frame and woven rope.

Dal baati: a Rajasthani dish of wheat dough balls baked over a fire and served with lentils.

Dheel: "give slack," which means let the string run out.

Dupatta: a long scarf worn over the shoulders or the head.

Feeni: a thin, crispy pastry from Rajasthan, made for Sankranti.

Gajak: a crunchy winter sweet made with sesame seeds and cane sugar.

Haveli: a large traditional house built around a courtyard.

Jalebi: a spiral of fried batter soaked in syrup.

Kandeel: a paper lantern that is lit and sent up into the sky on the evening of Sankranti.

Kathak: a classical dance from northern India, full of rhythmic footwork and spins.

Kesariya: a saffron shade, somewhere between orange and red.

Kheench: “pull,” which means take the string back in with quick tugs.

Makar Sankranti: a winter harvest festival in the middle of January. In Jaipur, it’s the biggest day of the year for flying kites.

Manjha: kite string made sharp with a coating. In India, nylon and other synthetic kite strings have been banned since 2017.

Masala chai: milky tea flavored with spices.

Pakode: vegetable fritters.

Paratha: a flaky wheat flatbread, often stuffed.

Patang: a paper fighting kite shaped like a diamond.

Poha: flattened rice cooked with spices, often eaten for breakfast.

Puja: a prayer and offering made at home or at a temple.

Rupee: the money used in India.

Til ke laddu: little balls of sesame seeds and cane sugar.

Woh kaata: “It’s cut!” The shout people call out when an opponent’s kite gets cut loose.

A Note on the Story



Ananya, her family, their lane, and their neighbors are made up. Jaipur, its kite markets, the festival of Makar Sankranti, the fabric dyeing and printing workshops of the city and of nearby Sanganer, and the dangers described in this book are all real.

Every year, in Jaipur and in other cities across India, kite strings injure birds, especially black kites, as well as people riding bicycles and motorcycles. Since 2017, a ruling by India's National Green Tribunal has banned kite strings made of nylon or other synthetic materials. During the festival, volunteers and veterinarians run emergency hotlines and care centers for birds. People are also asked not to fly kites early in the morning or toward the end of the day, when the most birds are in the sky.

In real life, a string you find in the street, on a roof, or in a tree should never be pulled or picked up with bare hands. Step away and tell an adult. A bird caught in a string should be left to a trained rescue service.

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

My Corner of the World follows four fictional young narrators in four countries on three continents. Each book can be read on its own, and they speak to each other in surprising ways.

Ananya's Notebook: The Stolen Flame

Anastasiya's Echo: Katya's Notebook

Sokha's Diary: The Road to the Bell

The Drum and the Ball: Lamine's Journal

